DOCUMENTATION

Admin Studio

Rebrand the login page, system emails, error pages, browser tab details and the admin dashboard of a WordPress site, starting from the colours and fonts of its theme.

Plugin version	1.0.0
Document date	20 October 2026
Requires	WordPress 6.4 or later, PHP 7.4 or later
Tested with	WordPress 7.1
Author	Láyò, www.layothedeveloper.com
Licence	GPLv2 or later

Contents

Part 1. Using Admin Studio

1. What Admin Studio does
2. Installing and first steps
3. Where each setting lives
4. Brand kit
5. Login page
6. Emails
7. Error and system pages
8. Tab and page details
9. Admin branding
10. Login protection
11. Coming soon and maintenance mode
12. Tools
13. Troubleshooting
14. Privacy and external services

Part 2. Developer reference

15. Requirements and compatibility
16. File structure
17. How settings are stored
18. Data the plugin stores
19. WordPress hooks used
20. Constants
21. Drop-in files
22. Security model
23. WordPress.org compliance
24. Release, brand assets and these documents

Part 3. Version 1.1 specification

25. Summary and status
26. Roles and permissions
27. Toolbar control
28. Admin templates
29. Dashboard widgets
30. Login screen text and links
31. Where the new settings live
32. Technical approach and build order

PART 1

1. What Admin Studio does

WordPress shows many screens and emails in its own default style: the login page, password reset emails, the "critical error" page, the "briefly unavailable" screen during updates, and the "Thank you for creating with WordPress" credit in the dashboard. Admin Studio restyles all of them to match a brand, from one place.

It starts from the active theme. Colours and fonts are read from `theme.json` on block themes and from theme settings on classic themes. The logo comes from the theme logo, and the favicon is the site icon. Change any value once in the brand kit and every screen follows, or override it for one area only.

Each feature can be switched off. A switched-off feature loads no code.

2. Installing and first steps

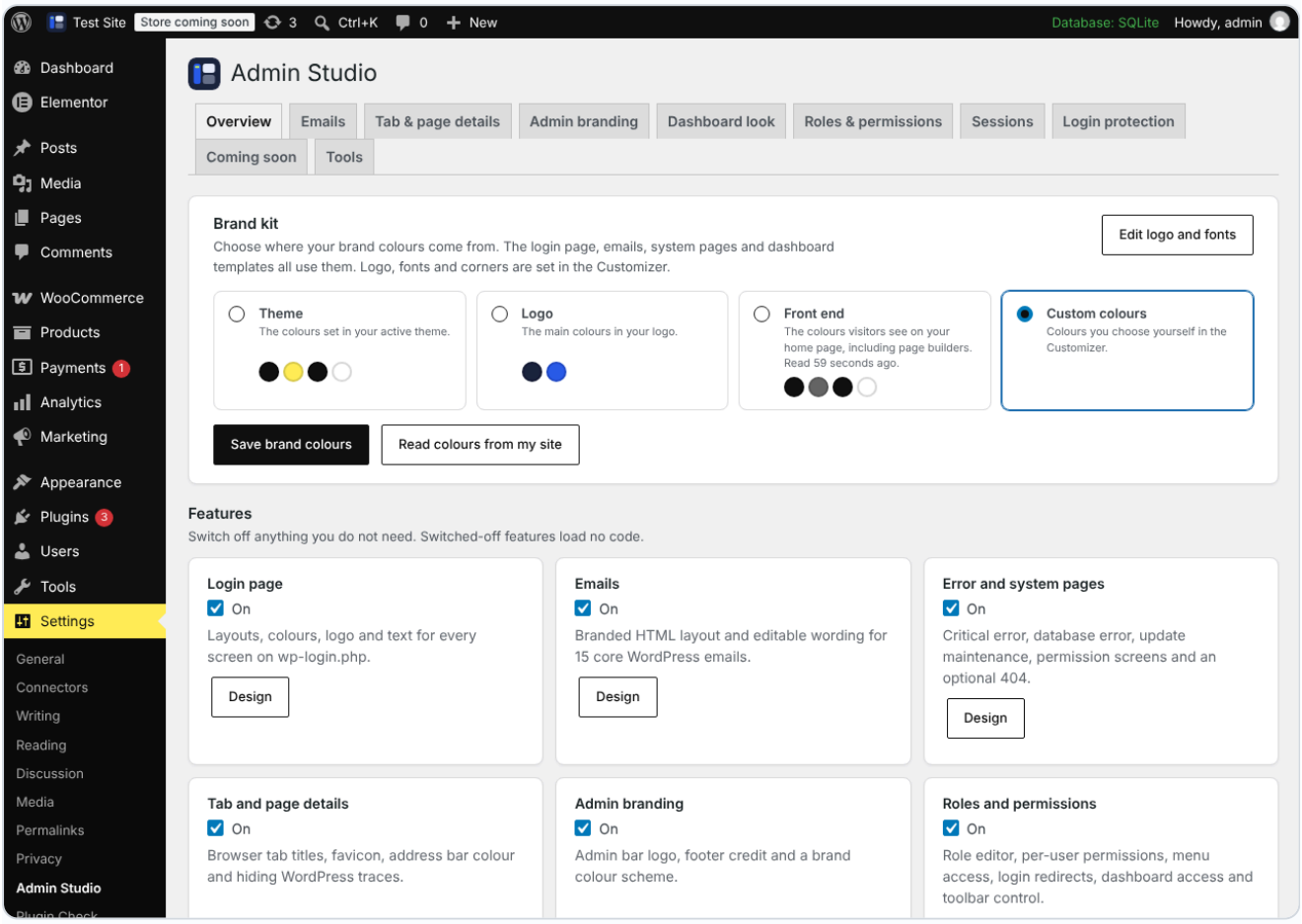
1. Upload the `admin-studio` folder to `wp-content/plugins/`, or install the zip from Plugins → Add New → Upload Plugin.
2. Activate the plugin. The login page, emails and error pages immediately take on your theme's colours and fonts.
3. Open **Appearance → Customize → Admin Studio** to adjust the brand kit and design the login page, emails and system pages with a live preview.
4. Open **Settings → Admin Studio** to edit email wording, admin branding, login protection, coming soon mode and tools.

3. Where each setting lives

Anything visual that can be previewed lives in the Customizer. Everything else lives on the settings page, where each group of settings sits in its own card and the Overview tab shows every feature as a card with its switch. Tables and cards share the same width, border and rounded corners. Every setting is always visible: switching a feature off does not hide its details, so you can read and fill them in before switching it on. Only a choice in a list (such as "Other address") reveals the box it needs.

Customizer (Appearance → Customize → Admin Studio)	Settings page (Settings → Admin Studio)
Brand kit	Overview: switch features on or off; uninstall option
Login page: layout, background, logo, form, button, text, custom CSS	Emails: subject, heading, body and button of each email; preview; test send
Emails: design (colours, logo, font, width)	Tab and page details

System pages: design and wording of each page	Admin branding
Coming soon page design	Login protection; Sessions; Coming soon access rules; Tools



Settings → Admin Studio, Overview tab.

Tabs with several parts, such as Roles & permissions and Dashboard look, list their sections under the tabs. With the WordPress default look they appear as WordPress's own sub-navigation (links separated by a bar, the current one in bold, as on the Posts screen). When you use an admin template, the tabs become one bar with only the current tab filled in, and the sections below it are plain text links with the current one in the accent colour, so the page never shows two rows of buttons.

4. Brand kit

The brand kit holds the values every area uses: logo, logo width, eight colours (primary, secondary, text, background, surface, border, success, error), a heading font, a body font, corner radius and button style (filled, outline or pill).

Where the colours come from

The Brand kit card on the Overview tab (and "Brand colours from" in the Customizer) offers four sources. Each option shows the colours it would give.

Source	What it uses
Theme	The active theme's colours. On block themes this is the theme.json palette and button colour; on classic themes it is common theme settings such as the primary or accent colour and the background colour.
Logo	The main colours in your logo: the most used colourful shades, skipping near-white and near-black. SVG logos are read for the colours they name; PNG, JPEG, GIF and WebP logos need the GD image library, which most hosts have. The result is kept until the logo changes.
Front end	The colours visitors actually see on your home page, read in your browser when you click "Read colours from my site": the button colour, the link colour, the text colour and the page background. This works with page builders such as Elementor. Read it again after redesigning the site. If a security setting stops the home page opening inside the dashboard, the card says so.
Custom colours	The colours you pick in the Customizer's Brand kit section. The colour pickers there only apply with this option.

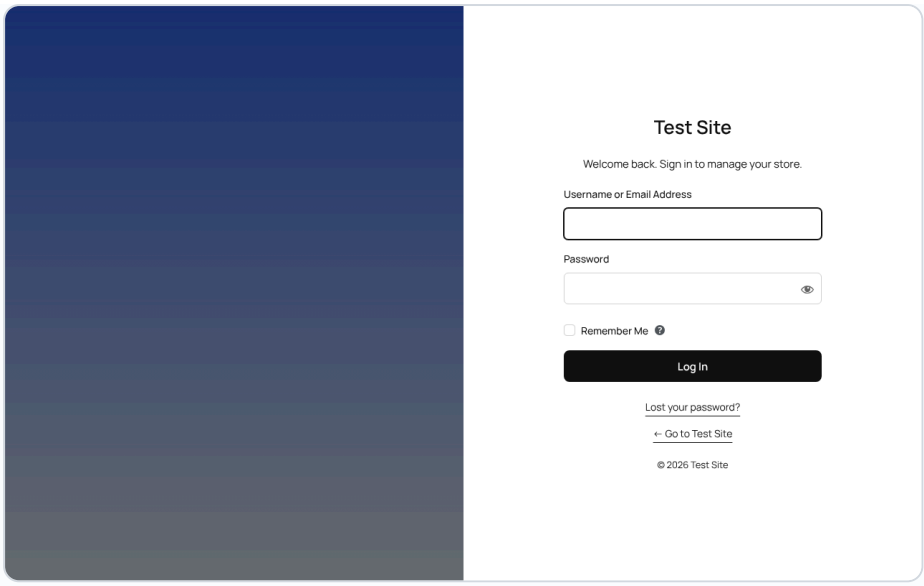
Anything a source does not provide (for example, a logo usually has no text colour) comes from the theme, then from a neutral built-in palette. Surface and border colours are derived from the background and text when not set, so dark themes get dark cards automatically. Sites set up before this choice existed keep their custom colours. Logo, fonts, corner radius and button style are set in the Customizer whichever source you choose.

Fonts

Choose "Same as theme", a system font, or one of 16 Google fonts. A Google font is downloaded to your site once, when you publish, and then served from your uploads folder. Visitors never load it from Google.

5. Login page

The design applies to every screen on the login page: log in, register, lost password, reset password, the two-factor code screen, and the "session expired" login that appears inside the dashboard.



Split screen layout using the Twenty Twenty-Five theme's colours and font.

Layouts

Layout	Description
Centered card	The form in a card in the middle of the page.
Split screen	An image fills one half of the screen; the form sits in the other half. Choose which side the image is on. On phones the image is hidden.
Full background	A full-page background with a translucent, blurred form card on top.
Minimal	WordPress's own layout, restyled with your colours and fonts.

Options

- **Background:** colour, gradient (two colours and an angle), image or video, with an overlay colour and strength. Videos are muted, looped and paused for visitors who prefer reduced motion.
- **Logo:** image (defaults to the brand logo), width, link (defaults to your home page instead of wordpress.org), text for screen readers, or hide it. With no logo image, the site title is shown as text.
- **Form and button:** width, padding, corner radius, background, shadow, field style (boxed, underline or filled), hidden labels with placeholders, text and link colours, button colour, button text colour (picked automatically for contrast when empty) and button corner radius.
- **Text and links** (Customizer → Admin Studio → Login: text and links): a message above the form, footer text, your own text for the "← Go to site" link (for example "Back to {site_name}"), options to hide the language switcher and the privacy policy link, and the layout and position of the links (below).
- **One message for failed log ins:** replace WordPress's "unknown username" and "incorrect password" messages with one message of your own. This also stops the screen revealing which

usernames exist.

- **Wording** (Customizer → Admin Studio → Login: wording): replace any of 23 pieces of WordPress's text on the log in, lost password, reset password and registration screens: field labels, "Remember Me", the button text, every link, the screen names (which also become the browser tab title), the instructions and the confirmation messages. Each box shows WordPress's own wording in your site language; leave it empty to keep it. `{site_name}` works everywhere, and `{login_url}` in the two messages that link to the login page.
- **Custom CSS** for anything else.

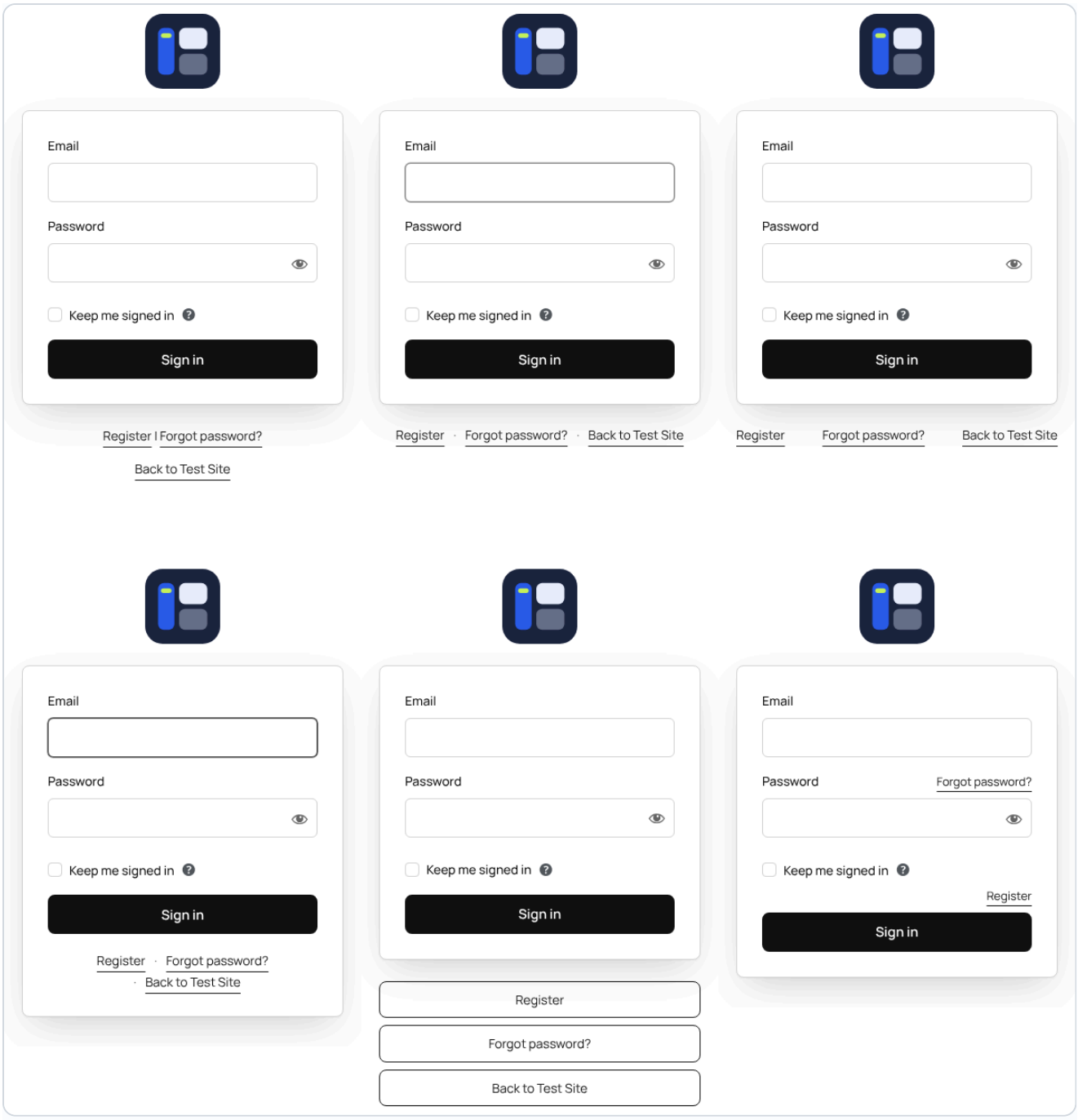
Links under the form

WordPress prints its links ("Register", "Lost your password?", "Log in" on the other screens, and "Go to site") in a plain row under the form. Choose how they are laid out:

Layout	Result
Stacked	WordPress's default: the links under the form, "Go to site" on its own line.
Inline	All links side by side on one row, separated by a dot. A link that wraps onto a new line does not start with a dot.
Split	The links spread across the width of the form, the first on the left and the last on the right.
Inside the card	The links move into the bottom of the form card, in the link colour.
Full-width buttons	Each link becomes a full-width outlined button.

Then place each link: **below the form** (in the layout above), **next to the Password label** (as most apps place "Forgot password?"), **above the main button**, or **hidden**. A link set to sit next to the Password label goes below the form on screens without a password field. "Register" only appears when anyone can register (Settings → General → Membership).

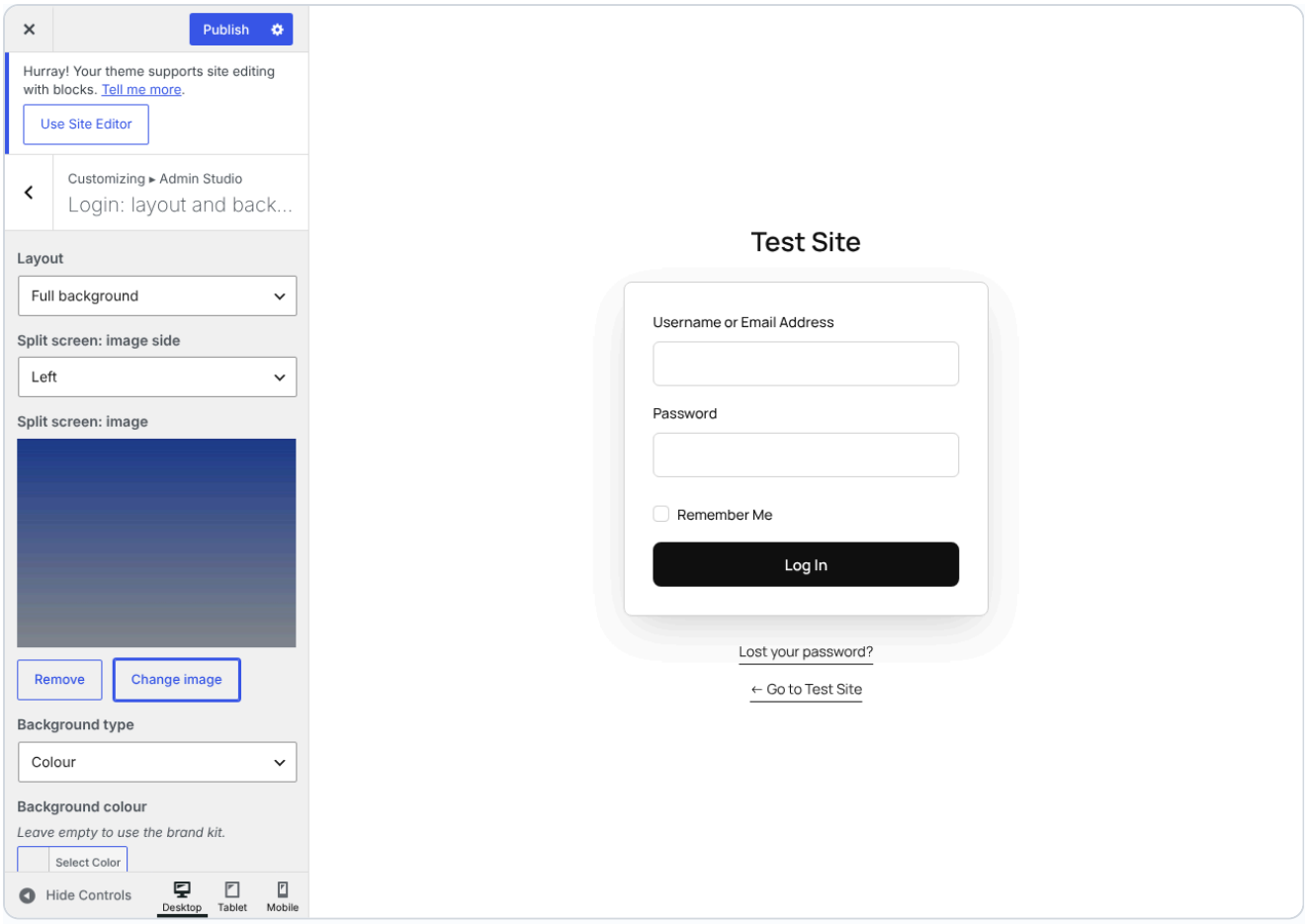
Hidden links stay hidden even in a browser without JavaScript. The other arrangements are made by a small script; without it, the links stay in WordPress's usual place. The "Hide Lost your password?" and "Hide Go to site" options from earlier versions became the "Hidden" position, and existing choices carry over.



Top: stacked, inline and split. Bottom: inside the card, full-width buttons, and "Forgot password?" next to the Password label with "Register" above the button.

The Customizer preview has a screen picker: log in, register, lost password, reset password and the two-factor code screen.

The Customizer warns when the text and background colours you pick have a contrast ratio below 4.5:1.



Designing the login page in the Customizer. The preview updates as you change settings.

6. Emails

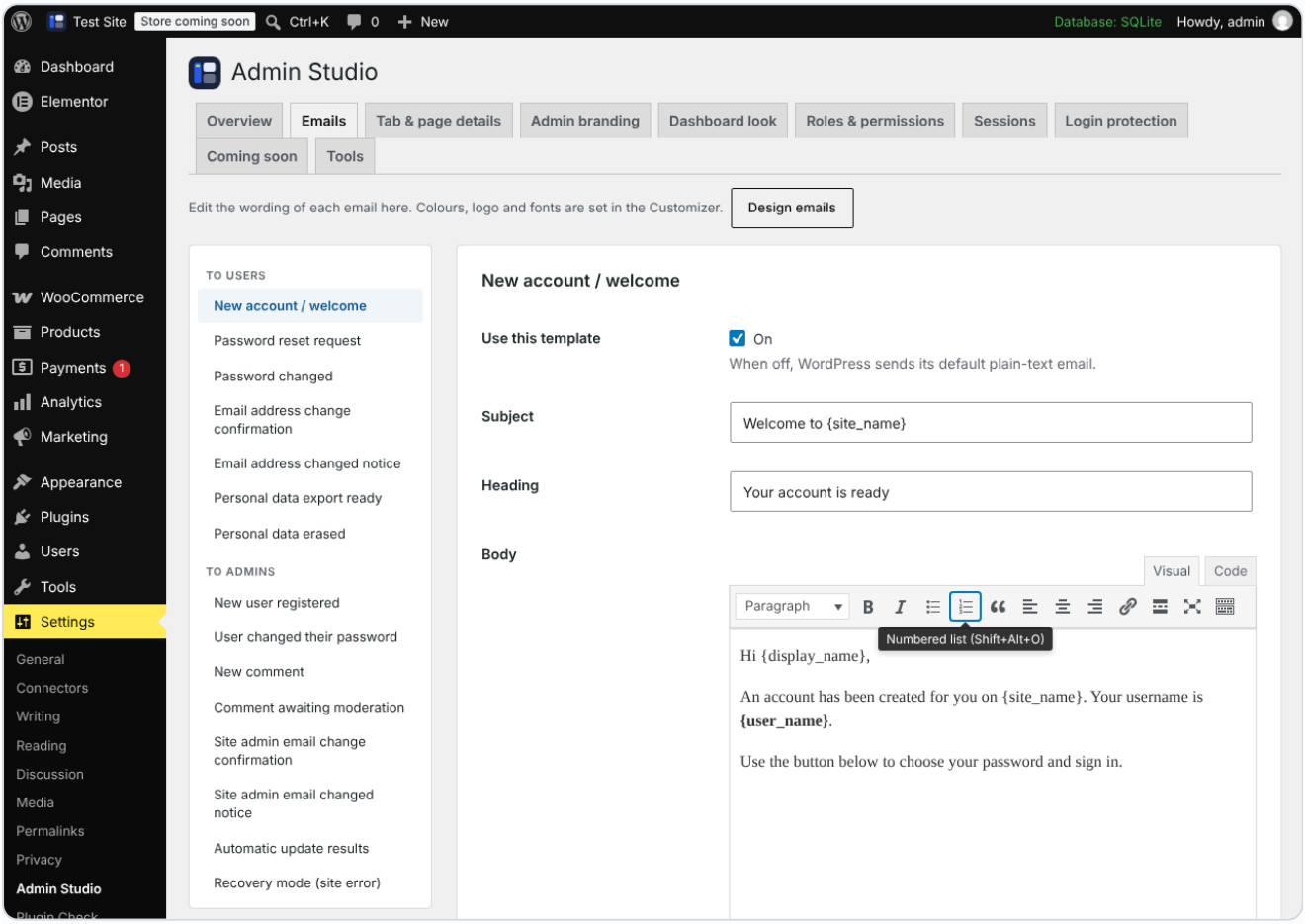
Admin Studio wraps 15 core WordPress emails in a branded HTML layout and lets you rewrite each one.

Sent to users	Sent to administrators
New account / welcome	New user registered
Password reset request	User changed their password
Password changed	New comment
Email address change confirmation	Comment awaiting moderation
Email address changed notice	Site admin email change confirmation
Personal data export ready	Site admin email changed notice
Personal data erased	Automatic update results; Recovery mode (site error)

Editing an email

Go to Settings → Admin Studio → Emails and pick an email from the list. Each email has an on/off switch, subject, heading, body and, where the email has a main link, button text. The body editor has a Visual tab and a Code (HTML) tab. Click a tag to insert it. Tags in braces, such as `{user_name}`, `{reset_link}` and `{site_name}`, are replaced when the email is sent. Unknown tags are left as they are, so nothing disappears silently.

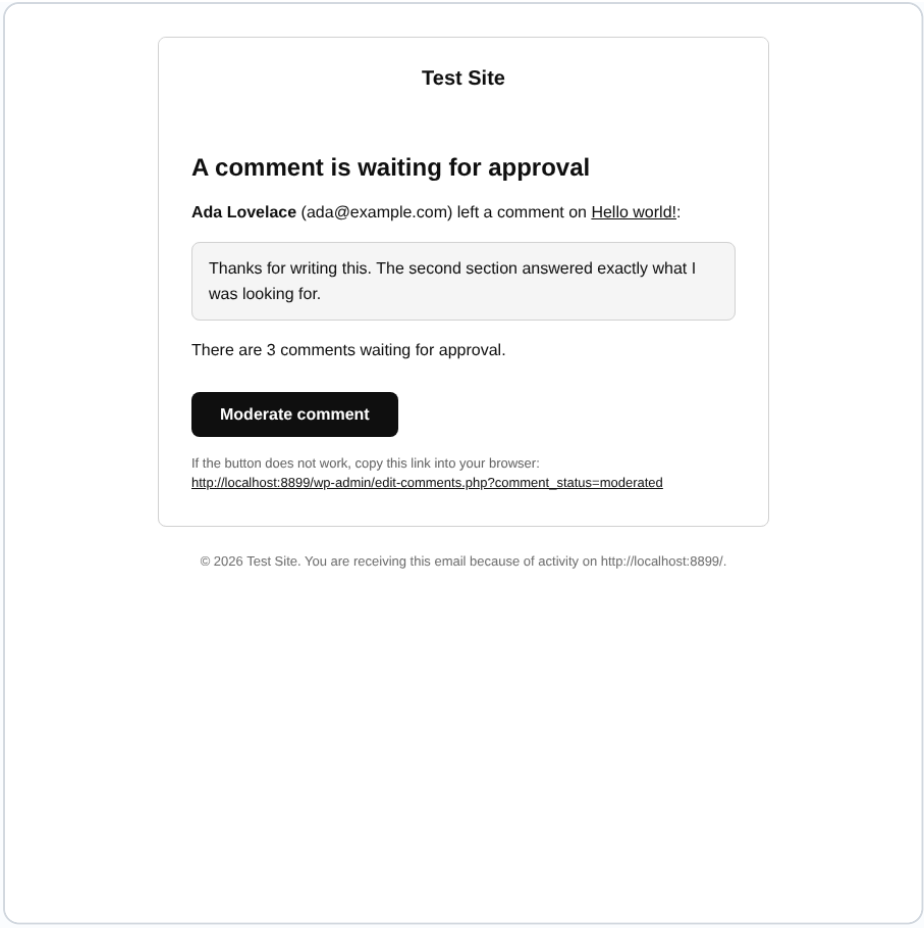
Every email also gets an automatic plain-text version for mail apps that do not show HTML. "Preview saved version" opens the email in your browser, "Send test email" sends it to any address, and "Restore default text" brings back the original wording.



Editing the "New account" email.

Design

Colours, logo, font, content width, corner radius and footer text are set in the Customizer under "Emails: design", with a live preview of any email. The layout uses tables and inline styles so it displays correctly in Gmail, Outlook and Apple Mail.



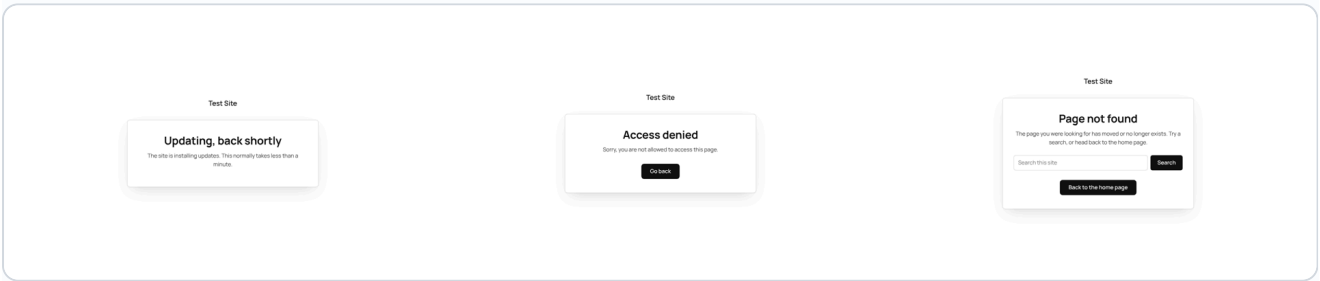
The "Comment awaiting moderation" email.

7. Error and system pages

Page	When WordPress shows it	How Admin Studio handles it
Critical error	A plugin or theme causes a fatal PHP error.	Writes `wp-content/php-error.php`. Returns status 500. API and AJAX requests get a JSON error instead. Signed-in administrators also see a "Message for administrators" (editable, empty to hide) explaining that WordPress emails a recovery link to the admin email address; visitors never see it. If the file cannot be written, the same page is shown through WordPress's own error handler, so "There has been a critical error on this website" never appears.
Database connection error	WordPress cannot reach its database.	Writes `wp-content/db-error.php` with a static copy of the design, because the database is unavailable. Status 500 with Retry-After.
Update maintenance	For a few seconds while updates install.	Writes `wp-content/maintenance.php`. Status 503 with Retry-After.

No permission	Someone opens a screen their account cannot use: "Sorry, you are not allowed to access this page" and the many similar messages.	Shows your own title, message and button (status 403). The button goes to the dashboard for people who can use it and to the home page for everyone else, or to a link you choose. Leave the message empty to keep WordPress's wording inside your design.
Expired link	"The link you followed has expired", after a form or link has been open too long.	Shows your own title and message, with a button back to the previous page.
Other notice screens	Any other short message WordPress shows on its own screen.	Replaces WordPress's notice screen live. The original message is kept.
Page not found (404)	A missing page. Off by default so your theme keeps its own.	Replaces the theme's 404 template, with an optional search box.

All pages share a design (background, card, text and button colours, logo, optional illustration) set in the Customizer, and each has its own title and message.



Update maintenance, a permission notice and the 404 page.

Safe with other plugins and hosts. Admin Studio never overwrites or deletes one of these files unless it wrote it. Each file it writes carries an "Admin Studio drop-in" line. If another plugin or your host already uses the file, the Tools tab says so and leaves it alone. Admin Studio removes its own files when you deactivate it.

8. Tab and page details

Browser tab titles

- **Admin, login, and error and notice pages:** each has a pattern using `{page}` and `{site_name}`. The defaults drop WordPress's "— WordPress" ending.

- **Your site's pages:** the separator between page name and site name, the 404 page title, the search results title (with `{query}`), and an option to show only the site name on the home page. These work with any theme that lets WordPress set the title, which includes all block themes and most classic themes.
- The names of the login screens themselves ("Log In", "Lost Password" and so on) are set under Login: wording (section 5).

Icons and colours

- **Favicon:** upload your own icon, or leave it empty to use the site icon from Settings → General. Your icon replaces the site icon everywhere WordPress prints it.
- **Icon everywhere:** show it on login, admin and system pages too, and fall back to the brand logo when there is no icon.
- **/favicon.ico:** browsers ask every site for this address. Without a site icon, WordPress answers with its own logo; Admin Studio answers with your icon instead (or nothing, if you have no icon or logo). A real favicon.ico file in your site's main folder always wins.
- **Address bar colour** on mobile browsers, from the brand primary colour.

WordPress traces

Each is a separate switch, all off by default:

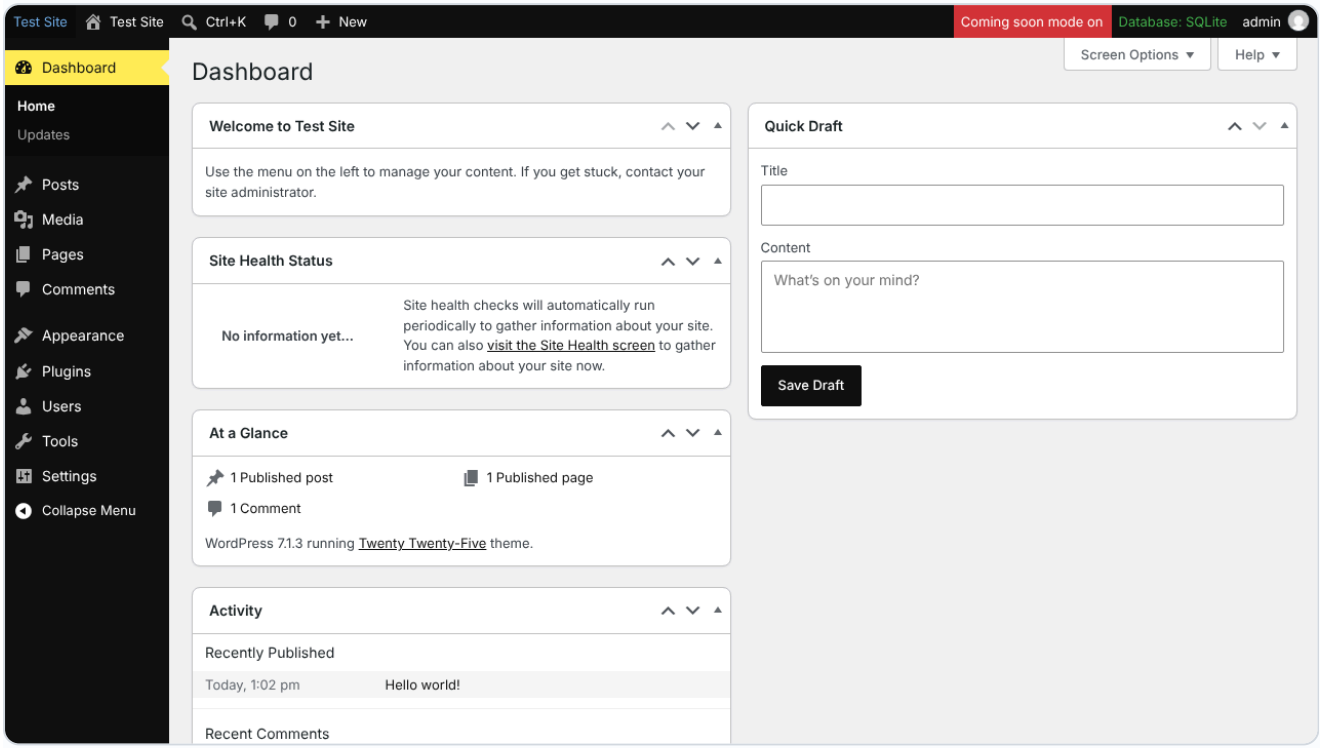
- Generator tag and feed generator; the WordPress version on core CSS and JavaScript addresses; the RSD and Windows Live Writer links.
- REST API, oEmbed and shortlink tags and headers. The REST API itself keeps working.
- WordPress's emoji script and styles.
- XML-RPC, pingbacks and the X-Pingback header. Requests to `xmlrpc.php` get status 403. Leave this off if you use Jetpack or the WordPress mobile app.
- Username lookups: visitors who are not logged in get a 404 for `?author=` addresses, cannot list users through the REST API, and author pages are left out of the sitemap.
- Point the login logo at your site when the Login page feature is off.

Some traces cannot be removed by a plugin, for example WordPress's `readme.html` and `license.txt` files, which you can delete from your server, and the folder names in image addresses.

9. Admin branding

- **Admin bar:** keep, replace or remove the WordPress logo menu; choose your own image and link. Optionally show just the user's name instead of "Howdy, Name".
- **Footer credit:** keep, replace or remove "Thank you for creating with WordPress" and the version number. Custom text supports basic HTML and `{site_name}`, `{site_url}` and `{year}`.
- **Admin screens:** remove the Help and Screen Options tabs. Dashboard widgets, including the welcome panel, moved to their own tab (section 29); earlier settings carry over automatically.

- **Colour scheme:** adds a "Brand" admin colour scheme built from the brand kit, which users pick on their profile. It can be the default for new users. When the brand primary colour would disappear against the menu, the scheme uses the secondary colour for the current item instead.



The brand colour scheme on the dashboard.

10. Login protection

Switch on any of the four features under Settings → Admin Studio → Login protection.

Custom login URL

Moves the login page to an address such as `/team-login`. Logged-out visitors who open `wp-login.php` or `/wp-admin` see a "page not found" page, are sent to the home page, or are sent to an address you choose. Every login, logout, registration and password link WordPress creates, including links in emails, uses the new address. The words "login", "admin", "dashboard" and WordPress folder names cannot be used.

Limit login attempts

After a set number of failed logins within a time window (default 5 in 15 minutes), the visitor's IP address is locked out for a set time (default 30 minutes). The login error shows how many attempts are left. IP addresses and IPv4 ranges on the allow list are never locked out. Turn on "behind a proxy" only if every request passes through Cloudflare or another proxy. The Login protection tab lists recent lockouts with an Unlock button.

Honeypot

Adds a hidden field to the login, registration and lost password forms. People never see it; bots that fill in every field are rejected.

Custom dashboard address

Moves the dashboard from `/wp-admin` to an address you choose, such as `/office`. It is set separately from the login address, and the two must differ.

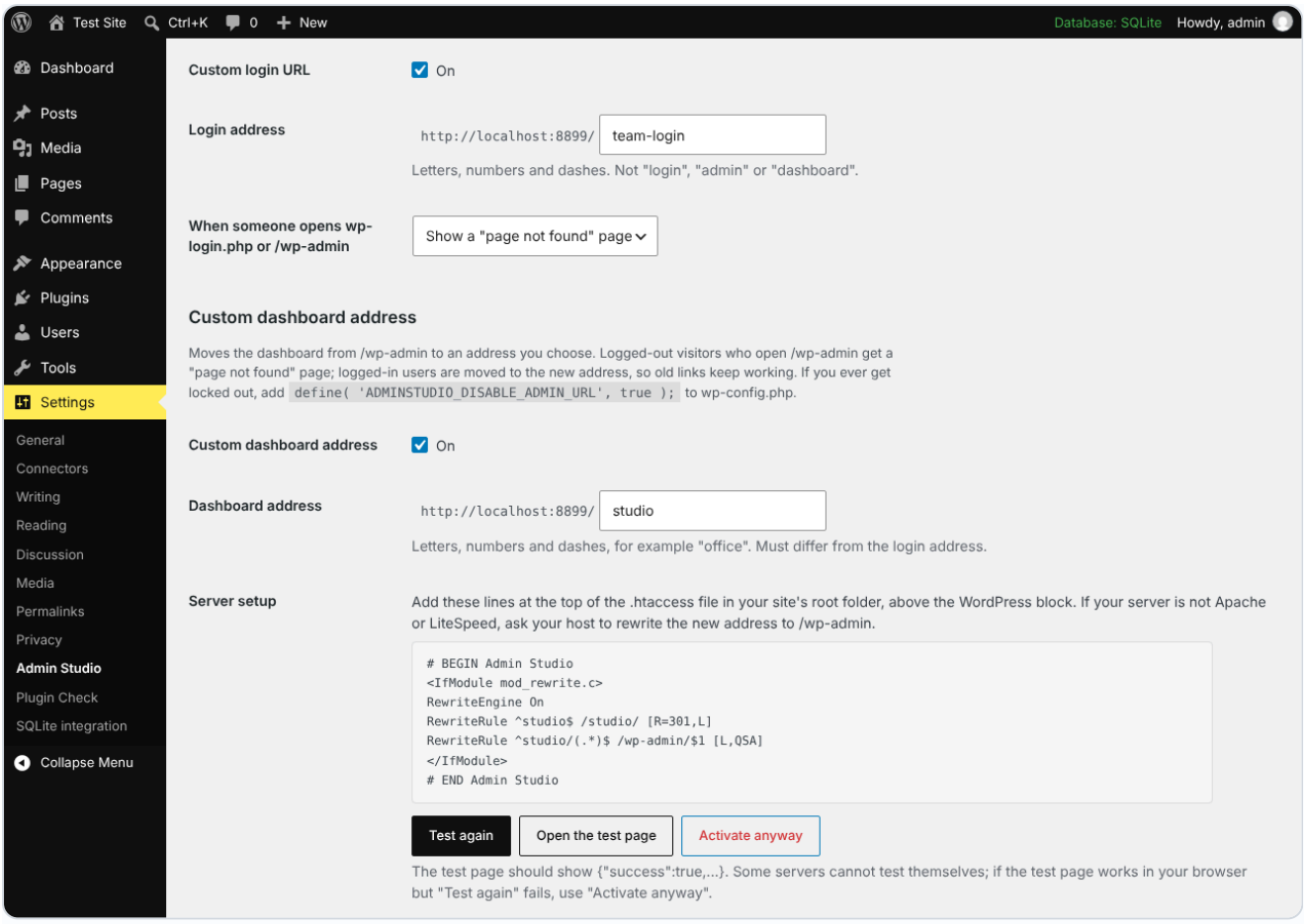
- Logged-out visitors who open `/wp-admin` see a "page not found" page. When the custom login URL is also on, the new dashboard address shows "page not found" to logged-out visitors as well, so neither address gives away the other.
- Logged-in users who open an old `/wp-admin` link, bookmark or plugin link are moved to the same screen at the new address. People already logged in when you switch move across without logging in again.
- Front-end features keep working: `admin-ajax.php` and `admin-post.php` stay at their usual address.

How it is set up

Because `wp-admin` is a real folder, the server has to send the new address to it.

- **Apache and LiteSpeed:** Admin Studio adds two rules to the top of `.htaccess`, above WordPress's own rules, and keeps a copy of the original file. Deactivating the plugin removes the rules.
- **Nginx and other servers:** the settings page shows the exact lines to add. Your host can add them for you.

After saving, Admin Studio requests a test page through the new address. The dashboard only moves once the test passes, so a missing rule never locks anyone out; until then it stays at `/wp-admin` and the settings page shows the rules, a "Test again" button and a link to the test page. Some servers cannot request their own pages. If the test page works in your browser but "Test again" fails, "Activate anyway" switches the address on.



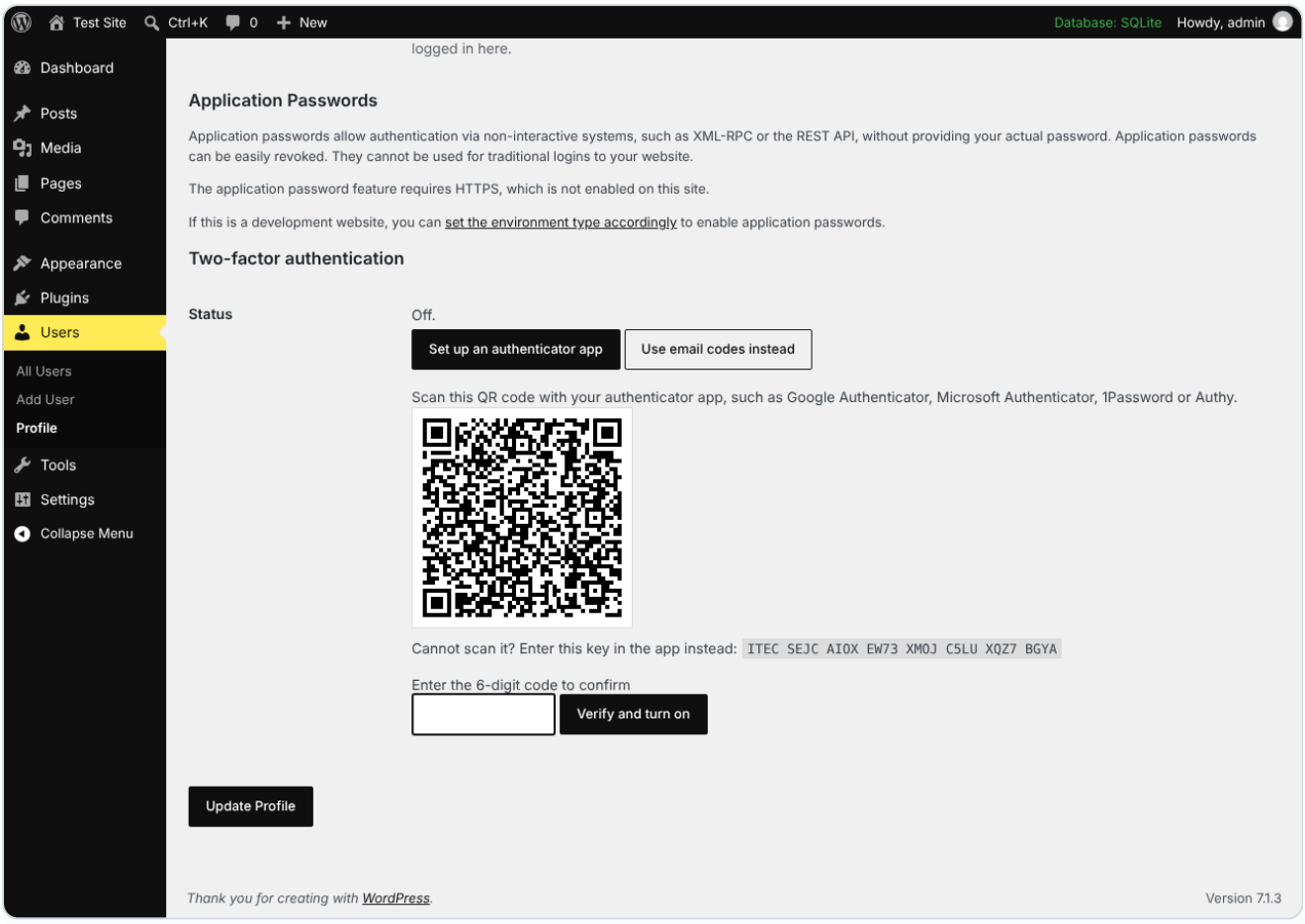
Waiting for the server rules, with the lines to add and the test buttons.

This hides the dashboard address, which stops most automated scans. WordPress's own scripts and styles still load from `/wp-admin` and `/wp-includes`, so it is one layer of protection, not a disguise. It is not available on multisite networks.

Two-factor authentication

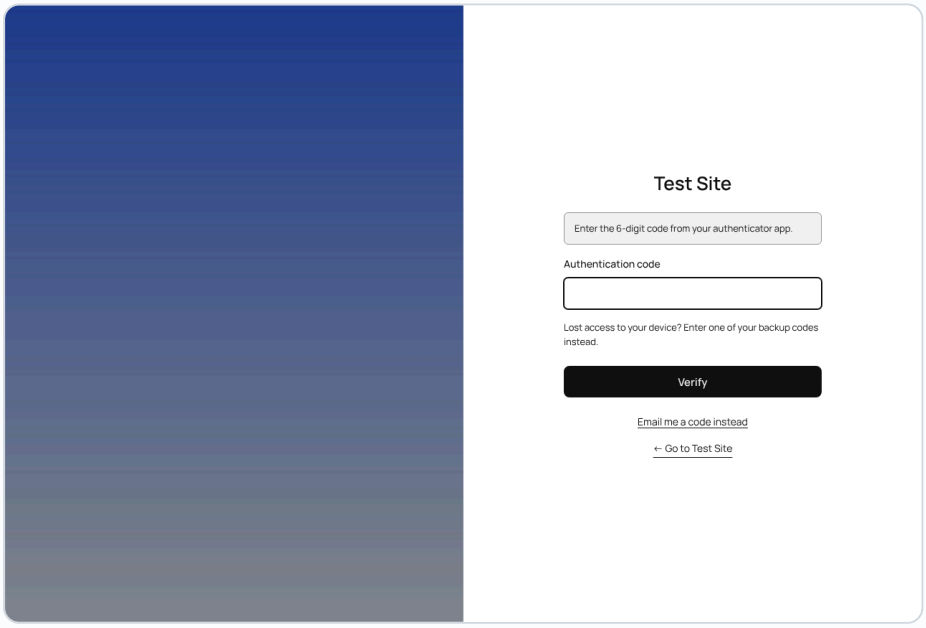
When switched on, each user can protect their account from their profile (Users → Profile):

1. Click **Set up an authenticator app** and scan the QR code with an app such as Google Authenticator, Microsoft Authenticator, 1Password or Authy. Or click **Use email codes instead**.
2. Enter the 6-digit code to confirm.
3. Save the 10 backup codes shown. Each works once.



Setting up an authenticator app.

After entering their password, users see a second screen asking for a code. They can ask for an email code instead or enter a backup code. Five wrong codes end the attempt, and wrong codes count towards the login attempt limit.



The code screen uses the login page design.

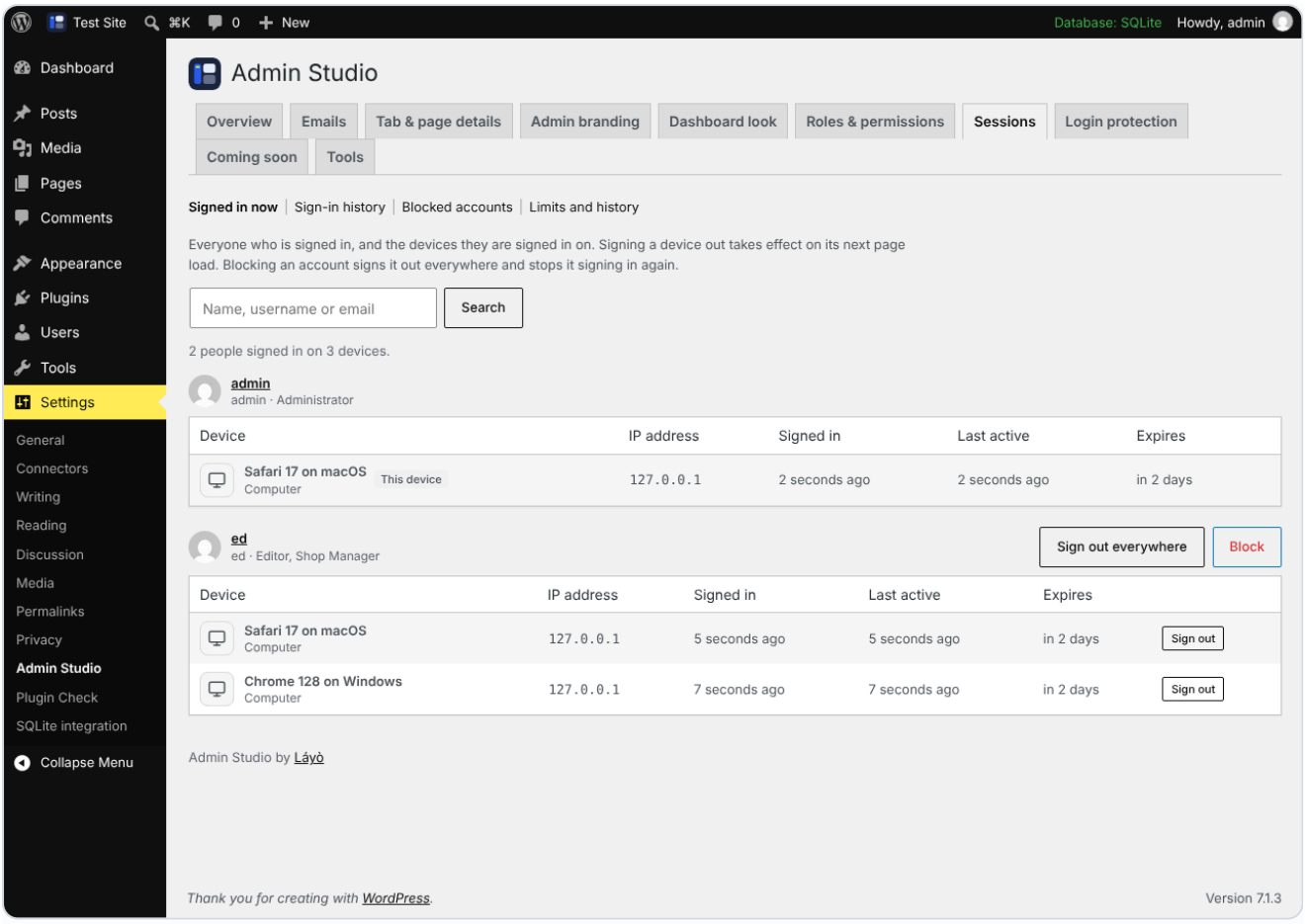
Administrators can require two-factor for chosen roles, with a grace period in days. Users in those roles see a reminder, and once the grace period ends they are sent to their profile until they set it up. Administrators can reset another user's two-factor from that user's profile.

Sessions and devices

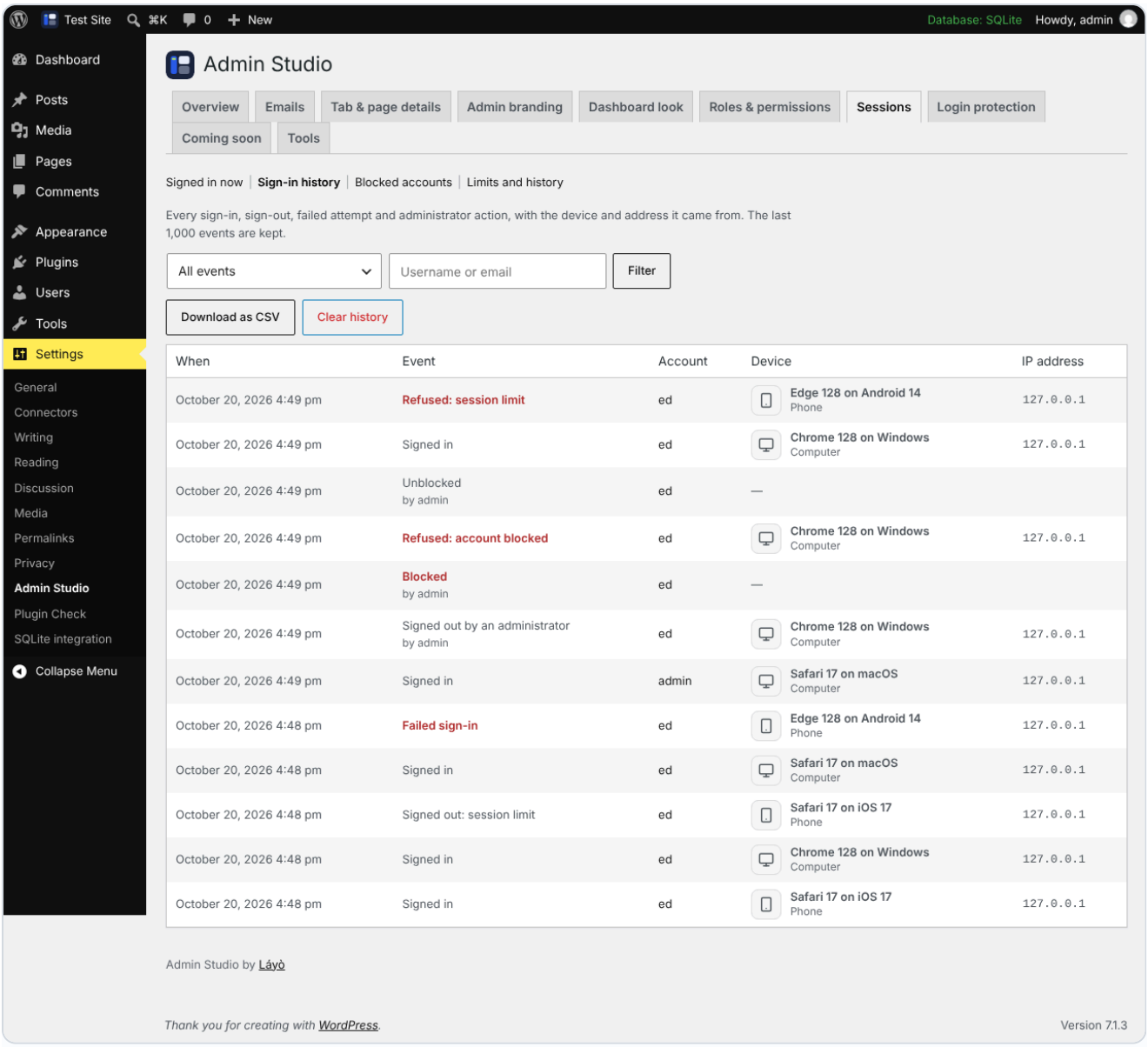
Settings → Admin Studio → **Sessions** shows who is signed in and where. Each browser or app someone signs in on is one session; Admin Studio reads WordPress's own sessions, so ending one signs that device out on its next page load.

- **Signed in now:** everyone with an active session, grouped by person, with the device (browser, system and whether it is a computer, phone, tablet or the WordPress app), IP address, when they signed in, when they were last active (updated every five minutes) and when the session expires. Your own current session is marked "This device".
- **Sign out** one device, **Sign out everywhere** for a person (for yourself: "Sign out my other devices"), or **Block** the account.
- **Blocked accounts** are signed out everywhere and cannot sign in, reset their password or use application passwords until unblocked. Their content is untouched. Block by username or email, or from the Users screen. You cannot block yourself.
- **Session limit:** the most sessions one person may have at once. When someone goes over, either their oldest session is signed out or the new sign-in is refused. Apply it to everyone or to chosen roles; administrators are exempt unless you untick that. The limit also applies after a two-factor code.
- **Sign-in history:** sign-ins, sign-outs, failed attempts, sign-ins refused for a blocked account or the session limit, and every sign-out or block by an administrator (with who did it). Filter by event or account, download as CSV, or clear it. The last 1,000 events are kept. Recording visitors' sign-ins and failed attempts can be switched off; administrator actions are always recorded.
- **Users screen:** a Sessions column shows how many devices each person is signed in on (or "Blocked"), and each row has Sign out everywhere and Block or Unblock links.

A sign-in refused because the account is blocked or the session limit is full does not count towards the failed-attempt lockout, because the password was right.



Sessions → Signed in now.



Sessions → Sign-in history.

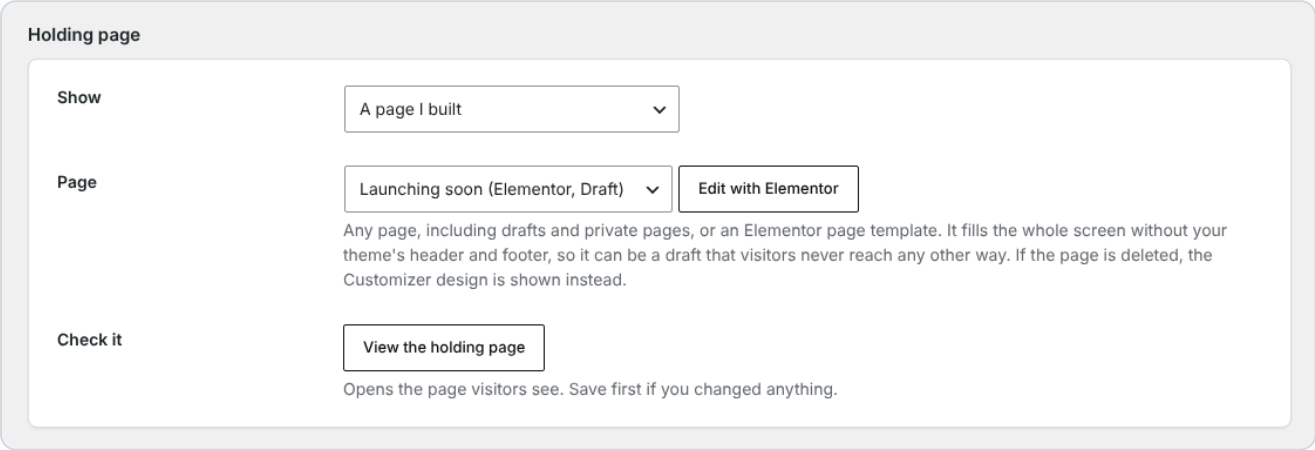
11. Coming soon and maintenance mode

Turn the mode on under Settings → Admin Studio → Coming soon. Under **Holding page**, choose what visitors see:

- **The page designed in the Customizer:** headline, message, countdown, logo, background colour or image, and text colour.
- **A page I built:** any page on the site, including drafts and private pages, or an Elementor page template (Templates → Saved Templates, type "Page"). Pages built with Elementor are marked in the list, and an "Edit with Elementor" button opens the chosen one. The page fills the whole screen without the theme's header and footer, so you can keep it as a draft that visitors never reach any other way. Elementor's styles and scripts load as usual. If the page is deleted or trashed, the Customizer design is shown instead.

"View the holding page" opens it for you as visitors see it, because administrators otherwise see the real site.

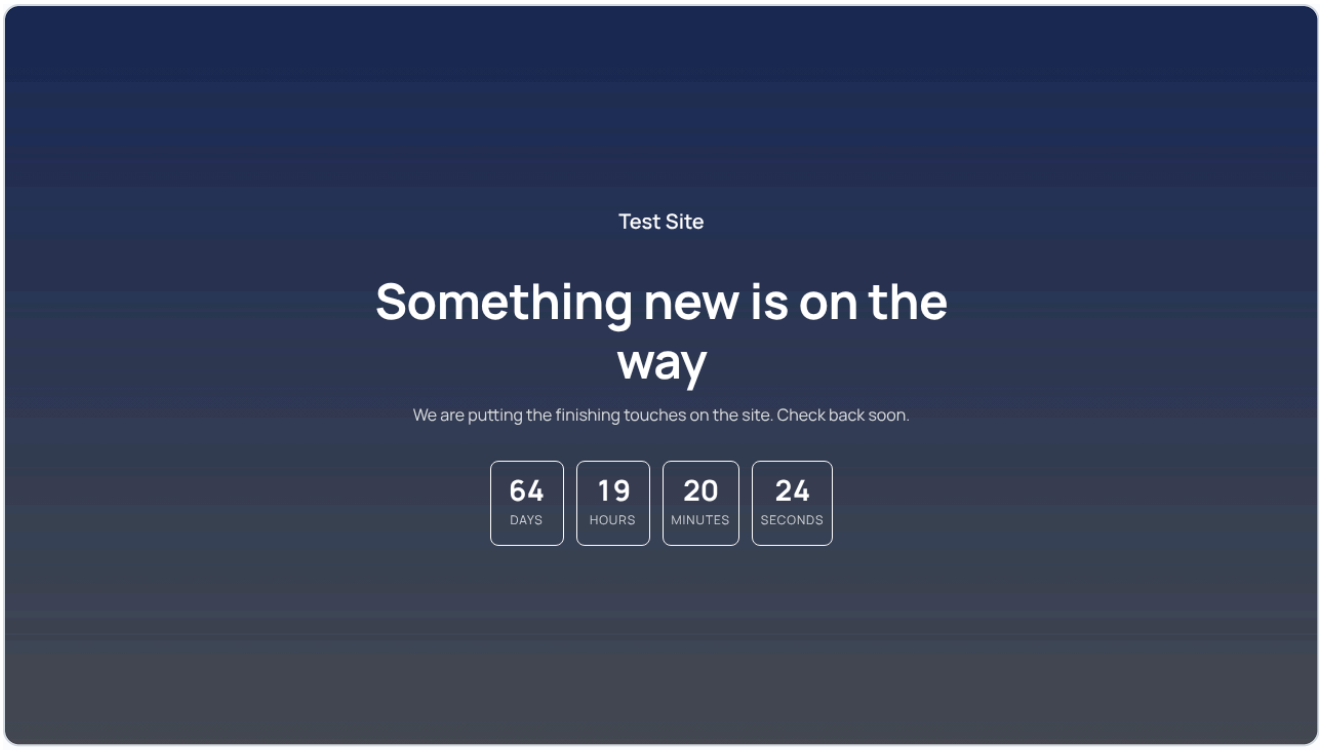
No way into the site. The holding page never lets a visitor open another page of the site. Every link that points into the site stops being a link: the logo, menus, buttons and links in the text, whether the page was built in the Customizer, the block editor or Elementor. These links stay: links to other websites, jumps within the page (`#signup`), email and phone links, and links to the "Always open pages" you listed. The admin toolbar is not shown on the holding page, even to logged-in users who cannot see the real site, and the page does not reveal its own address in canonical or shortlink tags.



Choosing an Elementor page as the holding page.

- **Coming soon** is for a site that has not launched. Visitors see the page with status 200 and search engines are asked not to index it.
- **Maintenance** is for a site that is temporarily down. The page is sent with status 503 and Retry-After, which tells search engines to come back later.

Administrators and the roles you choose see the real site. You can list paths that stay open (such as `/contact`) and create a bypass link to share with clients; anyone who opens it sees the real site for a week. While the mode is on, the admin bar shows a reminder.



Coming soon page with a background image and countdown.

12. Tools

- **Export** downloads all Admin Studio settings as a JSON file.
- **Import** replaces the settings with an exported file. Each value is checked and cleaned on import. Image addresses still point to the site they came from.
- **Reset** restores the defaults for one section or for everything, after a confirmation.
- **Status** shows the state of each drop-in file, whether `wp-content` is writable, the colours detected from your theme, and any active plugins that do the same job as an Admin Studio feature.

13. Troubleshooting

I moved the login page and forgot the address.

Add `define( 'ADMINSTUDIO_DISABLE_LOGIN_URL', true );` to `wp-config.php`, log in at `/wp-login.php`, check the address on the Login protection tab, then remove the line.

I moved the dashboard and cannot reach it.

Add `define( 'ADMINSTUDIO_DISABLE_ADMIN_URL', true );` to `wp-config.php`. The dashboard is back at `/wp-admin` straight away. Fix the setting on the Login protection tab, then remove the line.

I lost my phone and my backup codes.

Ask another administrator to tick "Reset two-factor for this user" on your profile. If you are the only administrator, add `define( 'ADMINSTUDIO_DISABLE_2FA', true );` to `wp-config.php`, sign in, set two-factor up again, and remove the line.

Test emails do not arrive.

Admin Studio only changes how emails look; delivery goes through WordPress's `wp_mail()`. Many hosts do not send mail reliably. An SMTP plugin usually fixes this, and Admin Studio's designs keep working with it.

The Tools tab says a drop-in is used by another plugin.

Another plugin or your host already provides that page. Admin Studio leaves it in place. Remove the other file if you want Admin Studio's version, then save any setting.

A Google font does not show.

The font is downloaded when you publish in the Customizer. If your server cannot reach Google Fonts, a system font is used instead.

14. Privacy and external services

Admin Studio makes no external requests and tracks nothing, with one exception: when an administrator chooses a Google font and publishes, the server downloads that font once from fonts.googleapis.com and fonts.gstatic.com. The request contains only the font name and the server's IP address. The files are then served from the site's own uploads folder. Google's terms and privacy policy apply to that request.

Two-factor secrets, backup code hashes and lockout records are stored in your own database. Lockout records hold the IP address and the username that was tried.

The sign-in history and the session list hold IP addresses and browser details, which count as personal data in many countries. Mention them in your privacy policy, or switch off recording sign-ins under Sessions → Limits and history. WordPress itself already stores the IP address and browser of every session.

PART 2

15. Requirements and compatibility

WordPress	6.4 or later; tested with 7.1
PHP	7.4 or later; checked with PHPCompatibility for 7.4+
Themes	Block themes (theme.json) and classic themes
Multisite	Works per site. Network-wide settings are planned for version 2.
Build step	None. Plain PHP, CSS and JavaScript.
Text domain	`admin-studio`; translation template in `languages/admin-studio.pot`

16. File structure

Path	Contents
`admin-studio.php`	Plugin header, constants, autoloader, activation hooks
`uninstall.php`	Removes data when the owner opted in
`includes/class-plugin.php`	Module registry and save side effects
`includes/class-settings.php`	Field schema, storage and sanitizing
`includes/class-defaults.php`	Translatable default text
`includes/class-brand-kit.php`, `class-color.php`, `class-fonts.php`	Theme detection, colour maths, font hosting
`includes/class-system-page.php`, `class-dropins.php`	Standalone pages and drop-in files
`includes/class-preview.php`, `includes/customizer/`	Customizer panel and preview routing
`includes/admin/`	Settings page, tabs and field renderers
`includes/modules/<module>/`	login, emails, error-pages, tab-meta, admin-branding, security, maintenance, roles, admin-look, sessions
`templates/notfound.php`	404 template
`assets/css`, `assets/js`, `assets/vendor`	Styles, scripts, QR code library

Classes use the `AdminStudio` namespace and are autoloaded: `AdminStudio\Modules\Error_Pages\Error_Pages` loads `includes/modules/error-pages/class-error-pages.php`.

17. How settings are stored

All settings are in one option, `adminstudio_settings`, as a nested array. Code addresses a setting by a dot path such as `login.layout`. The Customizer stores into the same option through setting ids such as `adminstudio_settings[login][layout]`, so both screens share one source of truth.

`Settings::fields()` defines every setting with a type (bool, int, color, url, select, multi, roles, html, css, slug, lines, datetime or text), a default and any limits. Every save from the Customizer, the settings page or an import runs through `Settings::sanitize()` for that type. Translatable defaults are resolved only after `init`.

18. Data the plugin stores

Where	Name	Purpose
Option (autoloaded)	`adminstudio_settings`	All settings
Option	`adminstudio_version`, `adminstudio_fonts`, `adminstudio_lockouts`	Installed version; downloaded font CSS; lockout log (last 100)
Transients	`adminstudio_count_*`, `adminstudio_lock_*`	Failed attempt counters and lockouts per IP hash
User meta	`adminstudio_2fa_*`	Two-factor method, secret, backup code hashes, last used time slice, pending login and email code
Files	`wp-content/php-error.php`, `db-error.php`, `maintenance.php`	Drop-in pages
Files	`wp-content/uploads/admin-studio/fonts/`	Downloaded Google fonts
Option	`adminstudio_admin_url`, `adminstudio_htaccess_backup`, `adminstudio_reapply_admin_url`	Which dashboard address passed its test; the original .htaccess; a flag to re-test after activation
Files	`.htaccess` block between `# BEGIN Admin Studio` and `# END Admin Studio`	Rewrite rules for the custom dashboard address (Apache and LiteSpeed only)
Option	`adminstudio_access`, `adminstudio_toolbar_nodes`	Menu, toolbar, login redirect and dashboard access rules per role; the toolbar items last seen, so the settings page can list them
Option (not autoloaded)	`adminstudio_role_backups`, `adminstudio_audit`	The last 20 copies of all roles; the activity log

Option (not autoloaded)	`adminstudio_signins`	Sign-in history, last 1,000 events: time, event, account, username tried, IP address, browser, and the administrator who acted
User meta	`adminstudio_login_redirect`	A person's own login destination, as a short token such as `profile`, `page:12` or `url:https://…`
User meta	`adminstudio_blocked`; `last_seen` added to WordPress's own `session_tokens`	When and by whom an account was blocked; when each session was last active
Option (not autoloaded)	`adminstudio_brand_palette`	Colours read from the logo (with the logo address they came from) and from the front end (with the time they were read)
Option	`adminstudio_look`	Site template and palette, custom colours, templates per role, personal choice switch, sidebar sections and menu item labels, icons and order
User meta	`adminstudio_toolbar`, `adminstudio_look_admin`, `adminstudio_look_self`, `adminstudio_look_try`, `adminstudio_look_mode`	Per-user toolbar override; template set by an administrator; the user's own template; a template an administrator is trying; light, dark or system mode
Cookie	`adminstudio_bypass`	Lets a bypass-link visitor see the site during coming soon mode
Cookie	WordPress's dashboard login cookie, at the new address's path	A copy of the cookie WordPress scopes to `/wp-admin`, so the browser sends it to the custom dashboard address

19. WordPress hooks used

Module	Main hooks
Login page	`login_enqueue_scripts`, `login_head`, `login_headerurl`, `login_headertext`, `login_body_class`, `login_message`, `login_footer`, `lost_password_html_link`, `login_site_html_link`, `login_display_language_dropdown`, `the_privacy_policy_link`

Emails	`wp_new_user_notification_email`, `_admin`, `retrieve_password_notification_email`, `password_change_email`, `email_change_email`, `new_user_email_content`, `new_admin_email_content`, `site_admin_email_change_email`, `wp_password_change_notification_email`, `comment_notification_text`, `comment_moderation_text`, `wp_privacy_personal_data_email_content`, `user_erasure_fulfillment_email_content`, `recovery_mode_email`, `auto_core_update_email`, `auto_plugin_theme_update_email`, then `wp_mail` and `phpmailer_init`
Error pages	`wp_die_handler`, `template_include`
Sessions	`attach_session_information` (limit and history at session creation), `authenticate` (priority 90: blocked accounts and refused sign-ins), `init` (last active), `wp_logout`, `wp_login_failed`, `allow_password_reset`, `wp_is_application_passwords_available_for_user`, `manage_users_columns`, `user_row_actions`
Login wording	`login_init`, then `gettext` (WordPress's own strings, on login screens only), `login_site_html_link`, `wp_login_errors`
Tab and page details	`admin_title`, `login_title`, `document_title_separator`, `document_title_parts`, `get_site_icon_url`, `do_faviconico`, `admin_head`, `wp_head`, `style_loader_src`, `script_loader_src`, `xmlrpc_enabled`, `xmlrpc_methods`, `wp_headers`, `rest_endpoints`, `wp_sitemaps_add_provider`
Admin branding	`admin_bar_menu`, `admin_footer_text`, `update_footer`, `wp_dashboard_setup`, `admin_init` (colour scheme), `user_register`
Login protection	`plugins_loaded`, `wp_loaded`, `site_url`, `network_site_url`, `wp_redirect`, `authenticate`, `wp_login`, `wp_login_failed`, `set_auth_cookie`, `send_auth_cookies`, `login_form_adminstudio_2fa`, profile and AJAX hooks; for the dashboard address `admin_url`, `site_url`, `wp_redirect`, `set_auth_cookie`, `clear_auth_cookie` and the `adminstudio_ping` AJAX action
Coming soon	`template_redirect`, `admin_bar_menu`
Admin templates	`admin_body_class`, `admin_enqueue_scripts`, `admin_menu` (labels), `custom_menu_order`, `menu_order`, `get_user_option_admin_color`, `admin_head-profile.php`, profile hooks, and the `adminstudio_look_mode` AJAX action

20. Constants

Constant	Effect when set to true in wp-config.php
`ADMINSTUDIO_DISABLE_LOGIN_URL`	Turns off the custom login URL; wp-login.php works again
`ADMINSTUDIO_DISABLE_2FA`	Turns off two-factor checks at login

`ADMINSTUDIO_DISABLE_ADMIN_URL`	Turns off the custom dashboard address; /wp-admin works again

Internal constants: `ADMINSTUDIO_VERSION`, `ADMINSTUDIO_FILE`, `ADMINSTUDIO_DIR`, `ADMINSTUDIO_URL`.

21. Drop-in files

Drop-ins are regenerated at the end of any request that saves settings, and on activation. Each file contains a header with the signature "Admin Studio drop-in", sets the status code and headers, and prints a static copy of the page stored as a PHP string literal. Files are written through `WP_Filesystem` only when WordPress can write directly to disk. A file without the signature is never touched. All plugin-written drop-ins are deleted on deactivation.

22. Security model

- Every settings form and AJAX action checks a nonce and the `manage_options` capability (two-factor actions check the user's own session).
- Every value is sanitized on save by its field type and escaped when printed. HTML fields are filtered with `wp_kses_post()`.
- Two-factor stops the login cookie from being sent after the password step, destroys the session that was created, and only sets the cookie after a valid code. Login state tokens expire after 10 minutes. Authenticator codes cannot be reused. Backup codes are stored hashed.
- The attempt limiter trusts proxy headers only when an administrator turns that on.
- The custom login URL serves the real wp-login.php at the new address, so all core login behaviour is kept.
- The custom dashboard address only takes effect after a test request through the new address succeeds (or the owner confirms it). The copied dashboard cookie respects `send_auth_cookies`, so the two-factor step still withholds it until a valid code is entered.

23. WordPress.org compliance

The release copy is checked with the official Plugin Check tool and with PHPCS (WordPress Coding Standards 3 and PHPCompatibility for PHP 7.4+). Current result: **No errors, no warnings**

Rule	How Admin Studio meets it
GPL compatible	GPLv2 or later; the QR code library is MIT
No restricted terms in name or slug	Renamed from "Advanced WP" to "Admin Studio" because "WP" is restricted
No trialware, no locked features	Everything is included

No tracking or calling home	Only the opt-in Google Fonts download, documented in the readme with terms and privacy links
No front-end credit links	None. The author credit appears only on the plugin's settings page.
Don't hijack the dashboard	The only site-wide notice is the two-factor reminder for required roles, which disappears once set up
Human-readable code; no bundled core libraries	No minified or obfuscated code; uses WordPress's jQuery and PHPMailer
Escaping, sanitizing, nonces, no HEREDOC	Checked by PHPCS and by review; output is escaped where it is printed
Enqueue API for scripts and styles	All scripts and styles are enqueued or printed through core functions
Readme standard	Stable tag matches the version; tested up to 7.1; five tags; External services and Third-party libraries sections

Before submitting: set `Contributors:` in readme.txt to your WordPress.org username. It currently says "layothedeveloper", which is a guess.

24. Release, brand assets and these documents

The release zip contains everything except the files listed in `.distignore` (also marked `export-ignore` in `.gitattributes`): development notes, the `docs` folder and the `.wordpress-org` folder. The folder inside the zip must be named `admin-studio`.

Logo and directory assets

The logo is an abstract dashboard: a cobalt sidebar with a lime active item beside two cards, on a navy rounded square. The plugin uses `assets/images/logo.svg` on its settings page. The WordPress.org directory files live in `.wordpress-org/` and are uploaded to the SVN `assets` folder, not the plugin zip:

File	Use
`icon.svg`, `icon-128x128.png`, `icon-256x256.png`	Plugin icon in the directory and in Plugins → Add New
`banner-772x250.png`, `banner-1544x500.png`	Banner at the top of the directory page (normal and high resolution)

Colours: navy `#1b2340`, cobalt `#2a5bea`, soft blue `#e8eefc`, lime `#c6f05a`.

This document

This PDF is built from `docs/documentation.html` by `docs/build-pdf.js`, which prints the page with the Chromium browser that Playwright provides: `node docs/build-pdf.js`. The documentation is updated in the same change as every feature change.

PART 3

25. Summary and status

Status: in progress. Built and tested: roles and permissions (section 26), toolbar control (section 27) and admin templates (section 28). The editable wording from section 30 is built and documented in section 5. Dashboard widgets (section 29) and the login link layouts, link positions and Customizer screen picker from section 30 are built and tested too, and documented in section 5. Once version 1.1 is finished, these sections move into Part 1 and Part 2.

Version 1.1 extends Admin Studio from branding into running the dashboard: who can do what, how the dashboard looks for each person, and what they see first. It adds five areas:

1. Roles and permissions
2. Toolbar control
3. Admin templates (dashboard look), modelled on the portfolio site's admin panel
4. Dashboard widgets
5. Login screen text and link layout

26. Roles and permissions

Role manager

- Create a role from scratch or by cloning an existing one (for example "Shop Manager" from Editor).
- Rename any role's display name. Delete custom roles; if users have the role, choose which role they move to first.
- Show the number of users in each role, with a link to the filtered user list.

Capability editor

- Edit the capabilities of any role, including core roles such as Editor and Author.
- Capabilities are grouped: Posts, Pages, Media, Comments, Users, Appearance, Plugins, Tools, Settings, and one group per plugin that registers its own (for example WooCommerce), detected automatically. Unknown capabilities go in "Other".
- Each capability has a plain-language label and description, a search box, and "select all" per group.

Per-user permissions

- Give a user more than one role.

- Grant extra capabilities to one user, or deny specific capabilities that their role would otherwise give. Denials win.
- Shown as an extra section on the user's profile, for users who can edit users.

Menu access per role

- Choose which dashboard menu and submenu items each role sees, including items added by other plugins. Each menu is a small card with its submenu items, and the cards flow into columns, so even a long menu fits on one screen. A search box narrows the cards to the items that match.
- Hidden screens are also blocked when opened directly by URL; the visitor sees the branded notice screen.

Login redirect and dashboard access

- **Per role** (Roles & permissions → Login and access): choose where each role goes after logging in, Administrator included. Destinations: the dashboard home, their profile, the site home page, Posts, Add a new post, Pages, Media, Comments, Users, any published page on the site (picked from a list), or any other address.
- **Per person** (the user's profile → After logging in): the same choices for one account, set by an administrator. It wins over the role's destination. The Login and access section lists everyone with a destination of their own.
- Order: the person's own destination, then their role's (for someone with several roles, the first role that has one), then the home page for kept-out roles, then WordPress's default.
- Someone who logs in from a link to a particular screen still goes to that screen, unless "Always use these destinations" is ticked.
- If a chosen page is later unpublished or deleted, the next rule in the order applies instead.
- Keep chosen roles out of the dashboard entirely and send them to the front end. AJAX and REST requests keep working.

Safety

- The Administrator role is locked: its capabilities cannot be reduced and it cannot be deleted.
- No change can remove your own ability to manage users or this plugin.
- A copy of all roles is saved before each change. The last 20 copies can be restored, and "Restore WordPress default roles" resets core roles.

Audit log and export

- A log records who changed which role, capability, user permission or menu rule, and when, with filters and a CSV download.
- Roles, capabilities, per-user permissions and menu rules are included in the existing settings export and import.

27. Toolbar control

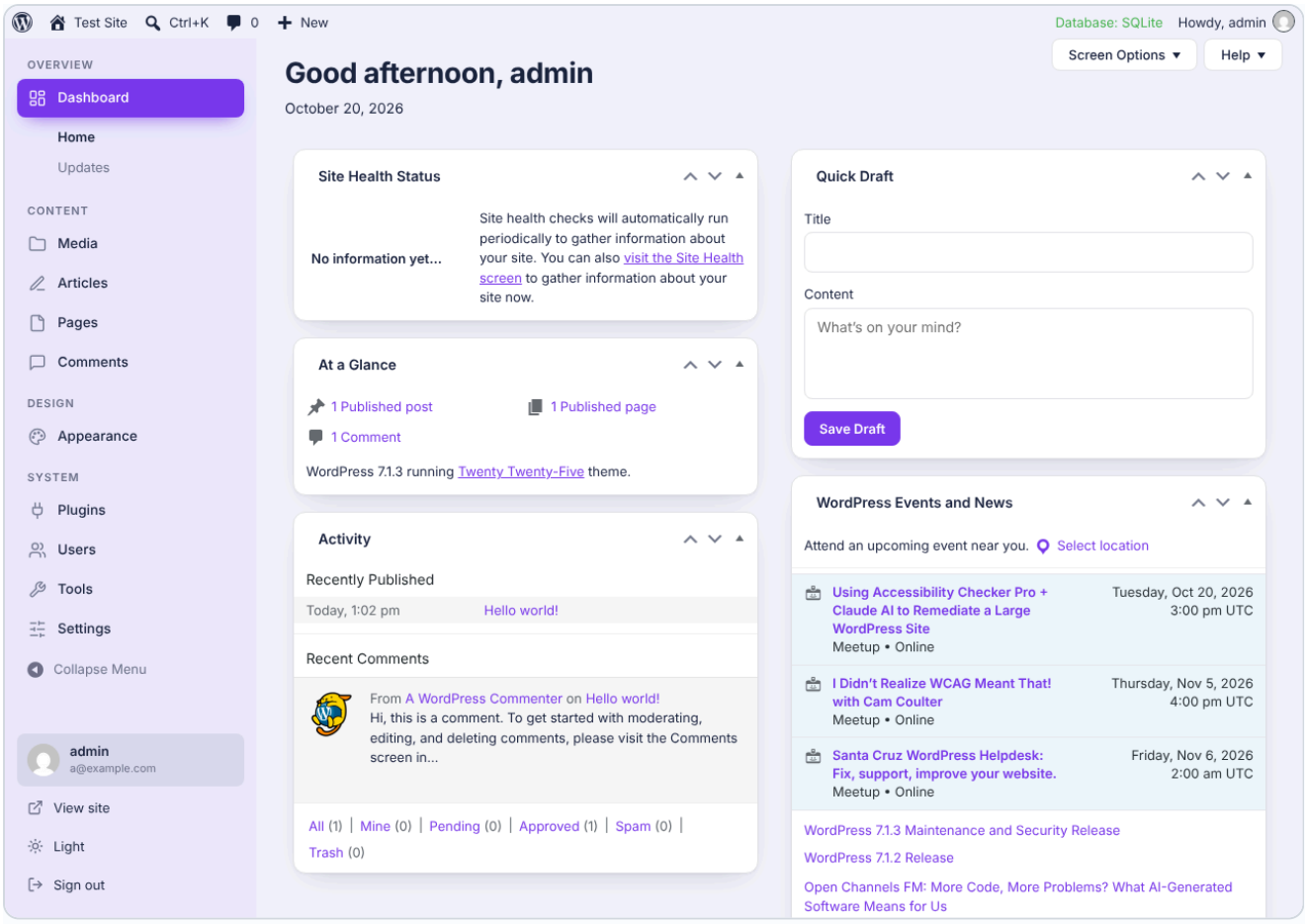
- Hide the top toolbar on the front end per role, with per-user overrides on the profile screen.
- Hide it inside the dashboard too. When it is hidden there, the account details, "View site", "Sign out" and the colour mode switch are in the sidebar footer, as in the portfolio admin panel. This option only takes effect for people who see an admin template other than "WordPress default". On phones the toolbar stays, because it holds the button that opens the menu.
- A user with several roles loses the toolbar only when every one of their roles hides it. Administrators always keep it.
- Hide individual toolbar items instead of the whole bar: comments, "+ New", updates, search, customize, and items added by other plugins (detected automatically). Per role.
- The table groups its columns under "Hide the whole toolbar" and "Hide one item". With many items it scrolls sideways while the Role column stays in place, and so does the role table on the Dashboard widgets tab.

28. Admin templates

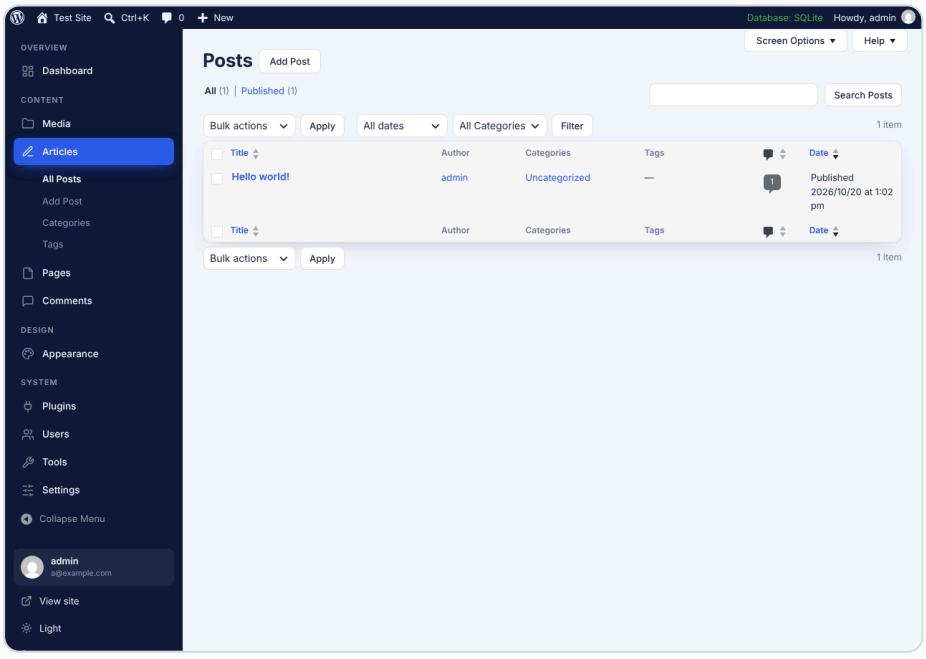
Templates change the look of the whole dashboard: sidebar, top bar, page headers, cards and meta boxes, tables, forms, buttons and notices. The block editor's canvas and panels keep WordPress's own design, because they change often between WordPress versions.

Templates in 1.1

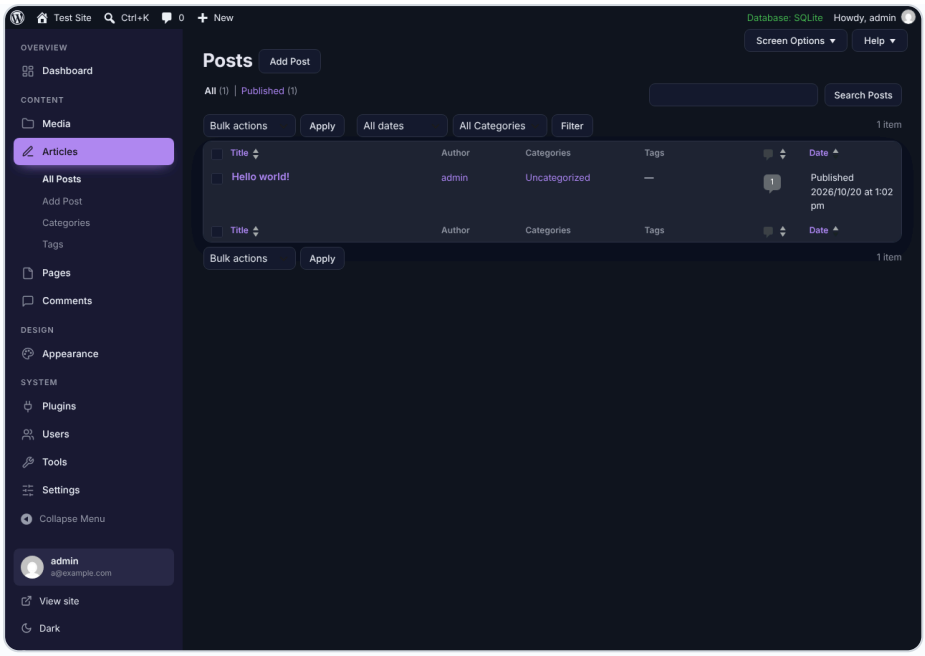
Template	Look
Studio	Based on the portfolio site's admin panel: a soft tinted sidebar with section headings (Overview, Content, System), outline icons with labels, the active item as a filled accent pill with a soft glow, pill badges for counts, rounded cards with a soft floating shadow, and a sidebar footer.
Midnight	Dark sidebar and top bar, light content area, bright accent.
Minimal	White sidebar, thin even dividers, no shadows; the accent appears only on text and icons.
Compact	An icon-only rail that expands on hover or focus, and denser tables, for power users and small screens.



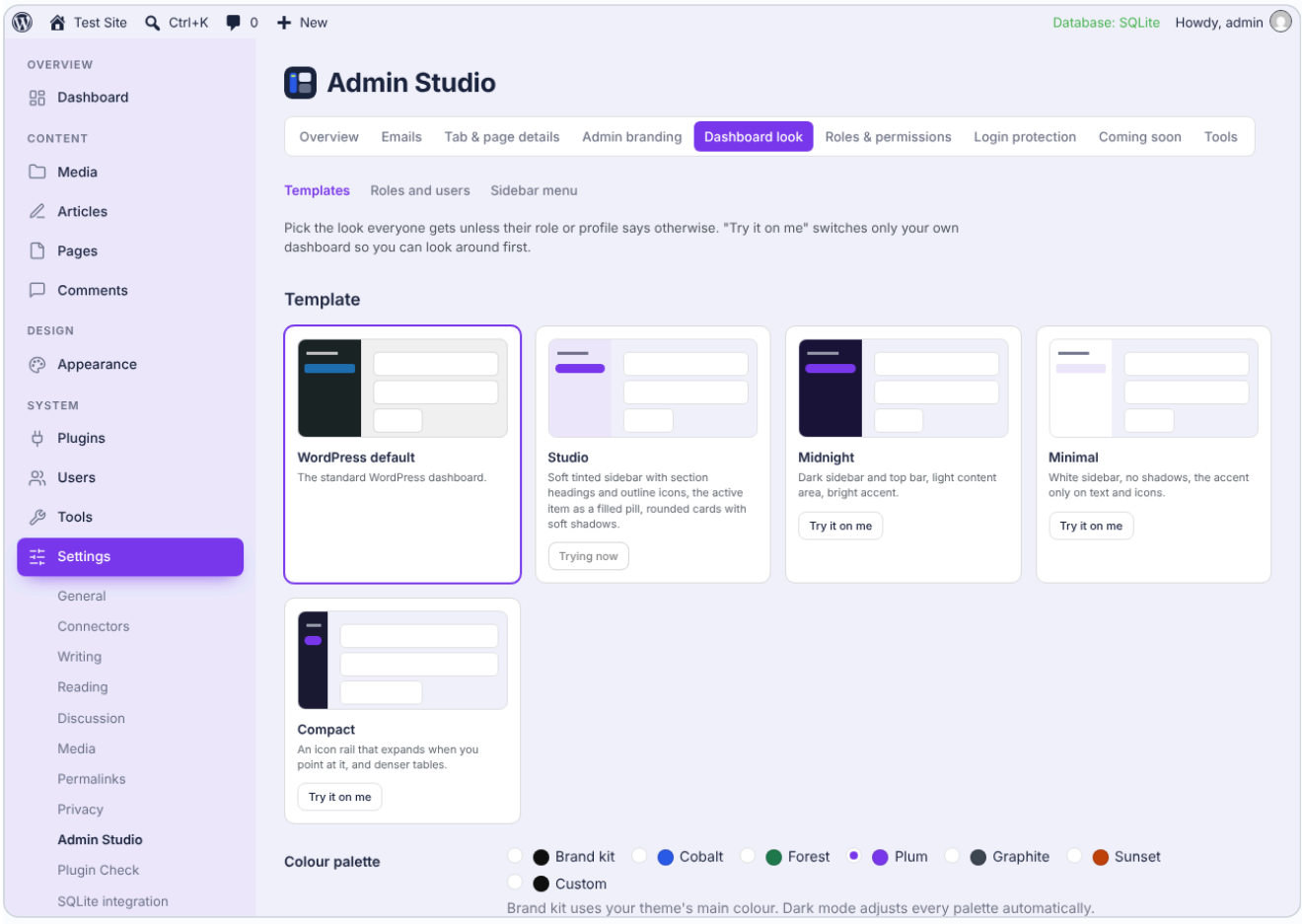
Studio with the Plum palette: section headings, outline icons, the greeting and the sidebar footer.



Midnight with the Cobalt palette.



Studio in dark mode.



Settings → Admin Studio → Dashboard look → Templates.

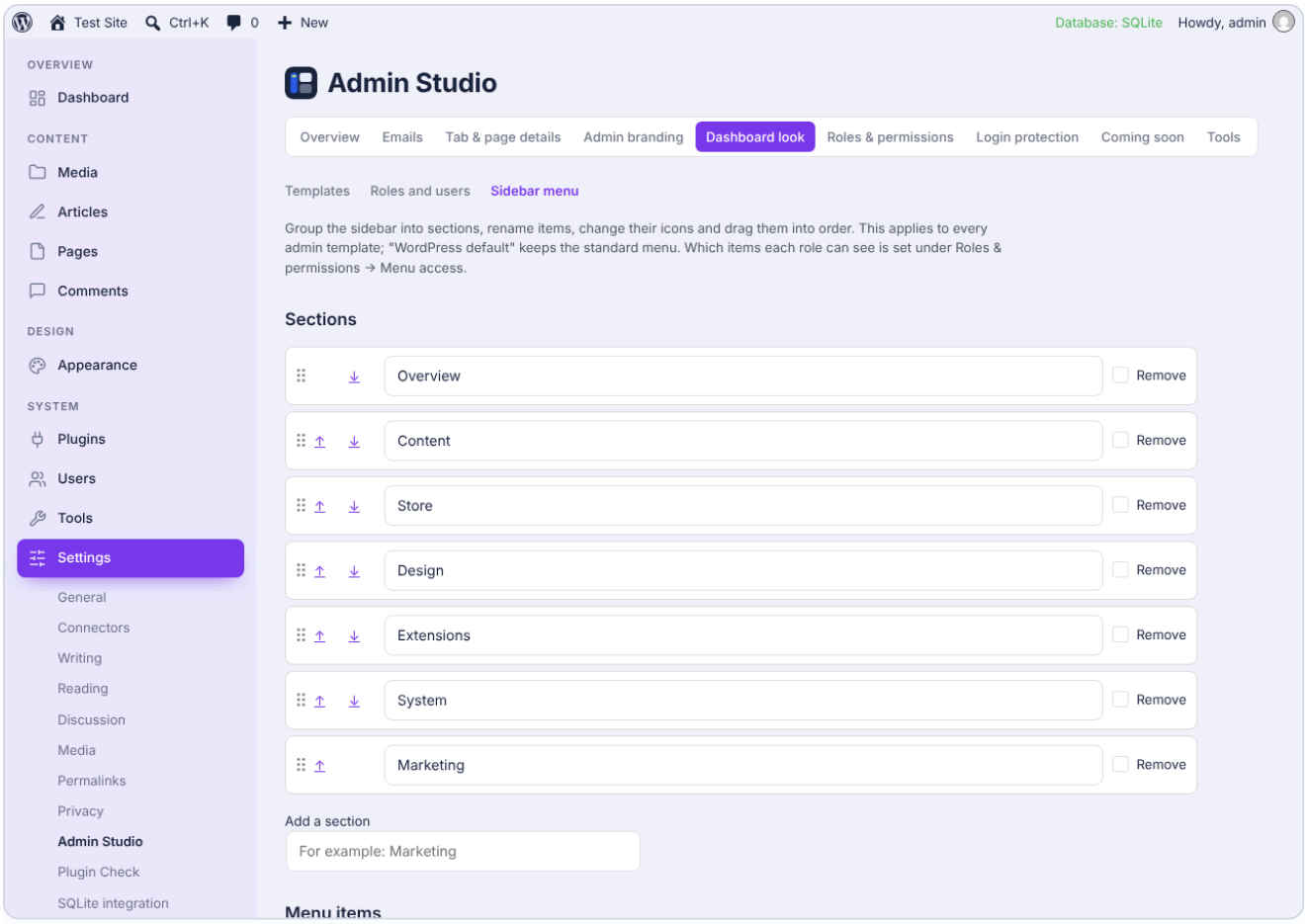
Colours and dark mode

- Colours follow the brand kit by default, so the dashboard matches the site out of the box.

- Ready palettes: Brand kit, Cobalt, Forest, Plum, Graphite and Sunset, plus Custom, where you set the accent, sidebar, background and text colours. Any colour left empty is worked out from the accent.
- Text and icon colours are chosen for contrast automatically. If the accent is too close to the sidebar colour (for example a black brand colour on the dark Midnight sidebar), the current menu item uses a lighter shade so it still stands out.
- Every template has a dark version. Users switch between light, dark and "system" (follow the device) with the button in the sidebar footer, or on their profile. The choice is saved per user.
- While a template is in use, WordPress's own colour scheme is set aside for that user and its picker is hidden from their profile. Their saved scheme comes back when they return to "WordPress default".

Sidebar menu

- Menu items are grouped into sections with headings. Admins can create sections and move items between them.
- Rename, reorder (drag and drop, or the up and down buttons from the keyboard) and choose an icon for each item from a bundled set of outline icons drawn in the style of Lucide (ISC licence). Core items get a matching icon automatically; plugin items keep their own icon unless you pick one.
- Sections can be renamed, reordered, removed and added. Items in a removed section fall back to their usual section. "Reset to the standard layout" clears every change.
- One menu layout for the whole site; each role only sees the items it is allowed (section 26).
- Sidebar footer: avatar and email, View site, Sign out, and the light/dark toggle.
- Hovered and focused menu items, including plugin menus such as WooCommerce, get a rounded tint in the template's colours instead of WordPress's dark row and side stripe. Keyboard focus shows a full ring.



Dashboard look → Sidebar menu.

Dashboard home

Each template also styles the dashboard home: a greeting ("Good morning", "Good afternoon" or "Good evening" with the user's first name) and the date replace the plain "Dashboard" heading, and widgets become rounded cards.

Who gets which template

1. Site default for everyone.
2. Per role, overriding the default.
3. Per user, set by an administrator.
4. Users can choose their own template and palette on their profile, unless "Personal choice" is switched off or an administrator has locked their role or account.

The most specific rule wins, in this order: a template an administrator is trying on themselves, the user's own choice, the administrator's per-user choice, the role, the site default. Settings → Admin Studio → Dashboard look → Roles and users sets the template per role and lists everyone with a template of their own.

Trying a template

"Try it on me" on each template card applies that template, with the palette selected on the page, to your own account only, and opens the dashboard so you can look around. A banner at the top of every screen then offers "Apply to everyone" (makes it the site default), "Apply to roles" (opens the per-role table) and "Stop trying".

29. Dashboard widgets

Settings → Admin Studio → **Dashboard widgets** has three sections. The feature can be switched off on the Overview tab.

Show and hide

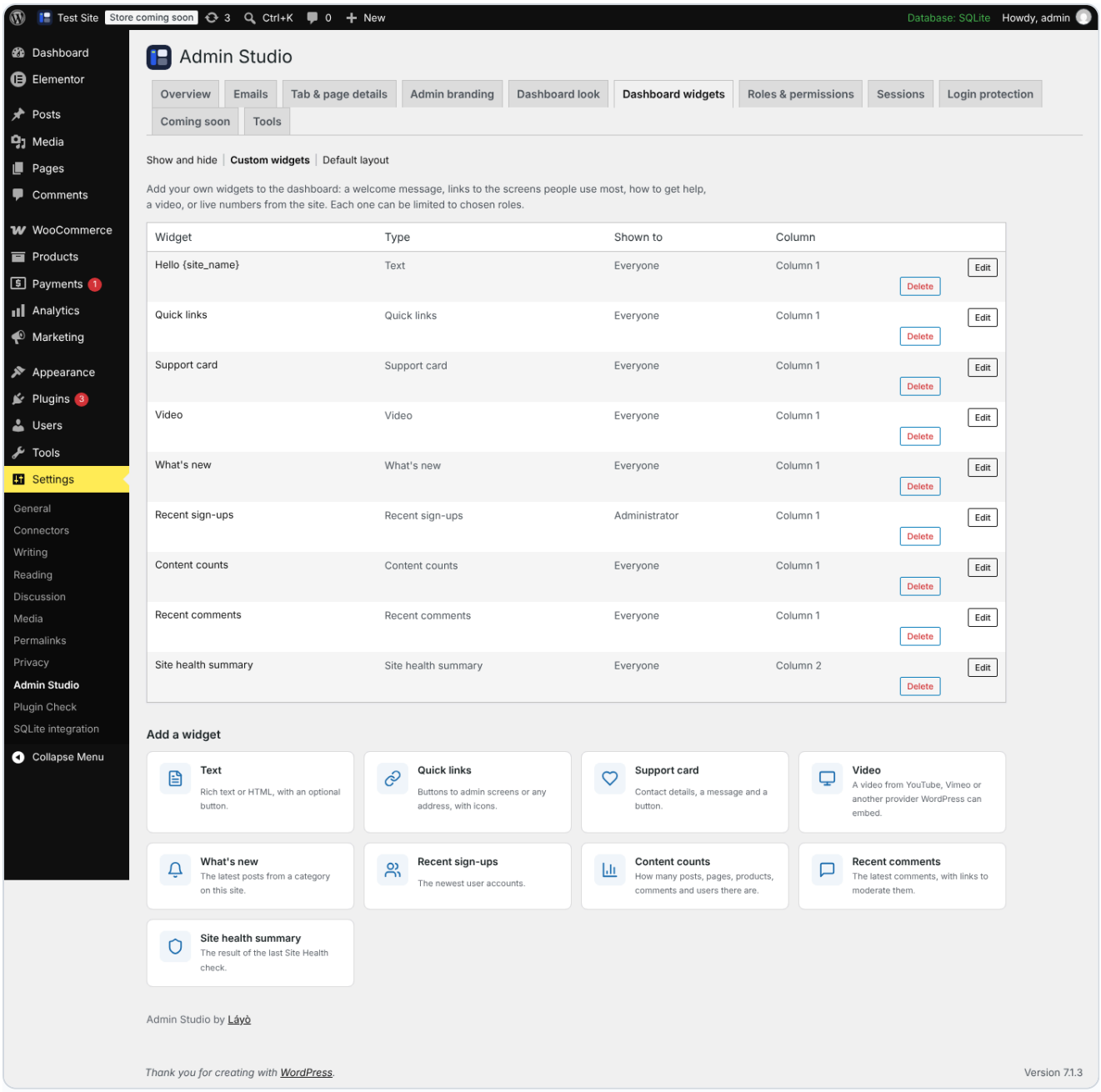
A table lists every dashboard widget with a column per role. Untick a role to hide that widget from everyone in it. The list starts with the WordPress widgets, including the welcome panel. Widgets from other plugins, such as WooCommerce or Elementor, are added automatically the first time an administrator opens the dashboard with those plugins active, and stay listed if the plugin is switched off for a while. Someone with several roles sees a widget if any of their roles does.

Custom widgets

Add as many widgets as you like. Each has a title (which can use `{site_name}`), a starting column, and the roles that see it; tick none to show it to everyone. The types are:

- **Text:** rich text or HTML with the Visual/Code editor and media button, plus an optional button.
- **Quick links:** up to 12 buttons, each with a label, an address and an icon. An address can be an admin screen such as `post-new.php` or `edit.php?post_type=page`, or a full address, which opens in a new tab. Drag rows to reorder them.
- **Support card:** a message, an email address, a phone number and a button.
- **Video:** the page address of a video on YouTube, Vimeo or another site WordPress can embed, with optional text underneath. The player loads from that site when someone views the dashboard; see External services in the readme.
- **What's new:** the latest posts from a category on this site.
- **Recent sign-ups**, **Content counts** (posts, pages, products and other content types, comments and users), **Recent comments** and a **Site health summary** from the last Site Health check. These show site data to everyone they are shown to, so limit them to the right roles. Links to edit screens only appear for people allowed to use them, and people who cannot moderate comments only see approved ones.

The welcome panel from earlier versions becomes a Text widget, and widgets hidden under Admin branding stay hidden for every role.



Custom widgets, and the types you can add.

Default layout

Arrange your own dashboard the way everyone should see it: drag widgets into place, collapse the ones that should start closed and hide any with Screen Options. Then click **Save my dashboard as the default**. The page shows the saved columns. People who have not arranged their own dashboard get the default straight away. Tick "Also replace the arrangement people have already made" to clear everyone's own order, collapsed and hidden widgets.

Lock stops people dragging widgets: they get the saved order and the move buttons disappear, though they can still collapse widgets. Administrators are never locked, so they can change the default. "Remove the default layout" goes back to the WordPress arrangement.

30. Login screen text and links

The aim is a login page that does not look like WordPress. Every word and the arrangement of the links under the form become editable, on the log in, register, lost password, reset password and two-factor screens.

Link layout

Layout	Result
Stacked	WordPress's default: one link per line under the form.
Inline	Links side by side on one row, separated by a dot.
Split	One link on the left, one on the right.
Inside the card	Links move into the bottom of the form card.
Full-width buttons	Each link becomes a full-width secondary button.

Position of each link

For each link ("Forgot password?", "Back to site", "Register", "Log in"), choose: next to the Password label (like most modern apps), above the main button, below the form, or hidden.

Editable text

- Link text. The "Go to site" link can have your own text without the arrow, for example "Back to {site_name}".
- Field labels and placeholders, "Remember Me", and button text (Log In, Get New Password, Save Password, Register).
- The instruction message on each screen, for example the lost password instructions and the "check your email" confirmation.
- A separate heading and message per screen.
- Changes appear live in the Customizer preview, which gains a screen picker (log in, register, lost password, reset password, two-factor).

31. Where the new settings live

Feature	Location
Roles, capabilities, menu access, login redirect, dashboard access, audit log	Settings → Admin Studio → **Roles & permissions** (new tab)
Per-user roles and permissions; per-user toolbar and template	The user's profile screen
Toolbar control	**Roles & permissions** tab, Toolbar section

Admin templates, colours, menu editor, assignment	Settings → Admin Studio → **Dashboard look** (new tab)
Dashboard widgets and default layout	Settings → Admin Studio → **Dashboard widgets** (new tab); replaces the widget options on Admin branding
Login text and link layout	Customizer → Admin Studio → **Login: text and links** (expanded)

32. Technical approach and build order

- No build step, as in 1.0: plain PHP, CSS and JavaScript, using WordPress's bundled jQuery and core accessibility helpers. Drag and drop has a keyboard alternative.
- Role changes use WordPress's own role API, so other plugins see them immediately. Per-user grants and denials use the `user_has_cap` filter. Role backups and the audit log are stored in options that are not autoloaded.
- Admin templates are CSS files layered over core admin styles with brand variables; the sidebar markup is WordPress's own menu with added section headings, so plugin menu items keep working.
- All new code follows the WordPress.org rules in section 23 and passes Plugin Check before each commit.

Build order

1. Login screen text and link layout
2. Roles and capability editor, with safety and backups
3. Per-user permissions, menu access, login redirect and dashboard access
4. Toolbar control
5. Admin templates: Studio first, then Midnight, Minimal and Compact
6. Menu editor and template assignment, including "Try it on me"
7. Dashboard widgets
8. Audit log, export and import, documentation and a full compliance pass

Each step ends with tests on a real WordPress install, an updated version of this document, and a commit.